Surf Dawn
User manual

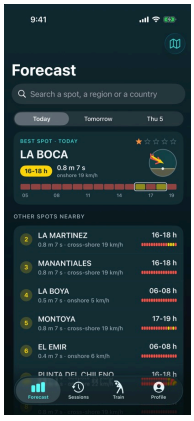
For Garmin watches, Apple Watch and iPhone











3 November 2026

The apps

Surf Dawn is three apps for your Garmin watch that work together, and an iPhone app that carries the Apple Watch app inside. They all share the spots, the best-hours calculation, the colours and the wording:

App	What it's for	How to open it
The face	See at a glance how the sea is at your spot: waves, wind, tide, water, air, sun and battery	It is the watch face
Forecast	See the day hour by hour and which hours are the best; in the morning, an alert with the day's best spot	Touch and hold the face, or from the app list
Session	Record your session, count your waves, find your way back to the spot and save everything to Garmin Connect	Touch and hold the water temperature, or from the app list
Apple Watch	Forecast, Today and Session in a single app, the morning alert, the complications and the Smart Stack	The Surf Dawn app on the watch, which comes with the iPhone one
iPhone	Each spot's week, your sessions with their waves on the satellite, Train (routines and apnea) and your profile; it receives the sessions from the Apple Watch and from Session on a Garmin	The Surf Dawn app on the iPhone

Getting started

With a Garmin (with the Apple Watch, see its getting started):

1. **Install the three apps** (see Install).
2. **Put the face on:** hold **MENU** (the middle button on the left) → **Watch Face** → choose **Surf Dawn** and press **START**.
3. **Keep your phone nearby** with the Garmin Connect app. Your spot's data arrives in a few minutes; until then the face says "LOADING".
4. **Choose your units and your background** in each app: on the face from Customize, and in Forecast and Session by holding **UP**. They come set to metres, km/h and the Sea background.
5. **Load your boards** on the phone: Connect IQ app → Surf Dawn Session → Settings → Boards. Session doesn't ship with any boards; if you don't load them, sessions are recorded without a board.
6. **Tell it how you surf:** in Session, by holding **UP**: **Stance** (Goofy by default, or Regular) and **Watch on** (your wrist, left by default). With your stance, each wave is logged as frontside or backside.
7. **Check the forecast:** touch and hold the face. The three best hours of the day come marked.
8. **Before you go in the water,** open Session, wait for the satellite at the bottom left to turn **green** and press **START**.
9. **In the water you don't need to touch anything.** If you want, press **BACK twice** after each wave to mark it: that is how the watch learns to count your waves. With DOWN you go from the session to the compass pointing back to the spot, the forecast and your waves (UP goes back).
10. **When you come out: START → Save → START**. Look at the summary, give it stars and tags, and that's it: it is saved in Garmin Connect.

A tip for your watch: under **Display → During activity**, choose **Always on**, so you can see the session without touching anything.

The buttons

Supported Garmin watches have five buttons: on the left **LIGHT** (top), **UP** (middle; held down it is **MENU**) and **DOWN** (bottom); on the right **START** (top) and **BACK** (bottom).

Button	Forecast	Session, before entering	Session, in the water
START	Request the data again	Start the session	Open the menu (Save, Pause, Waves…)
BACK	Exit	Exit	Nothing; **twice** marks a wave
UP	Choose the spot	See the day's conditions	Previous page
DOWN	The Today page: the day hour by hour	Menu: routines, apnea (test and CO2 and O2 tables) and Settings	Next page
UP held (MENU)	Settings	Settings	Settings
LIGHT held	Watch controls: light, inReach, SOS	same	same

The face doesn't use buttons: on watches with a touchscreen, touching and holding it opens Forecast, Session, or the watch's weather or battery (Gestures).

The Surf Dawn watch face

A watch face with hands (or with the time in digits) that shows you the sea at the spot where you are: waves, wind, tide, water and air temperature, the sun and the battery. It picks the nearest spot on its own and updates itself every half hour (every 15 minutes between 5 and 10 in the morning).

It has four backgrounds: **Sea**, **Night**, **Graphite** and **Forest**.



And the same information with the time in digits:



What you see

Where	What it is	What it's for
Top	The time of the next sunrise (yellow sun) and the next sunset (orange sun)	Planning your first and last session
Top middle	The battery: green (over 50 %), yellow (20 to 50 %) or red (under 20 %)	
Circle with the droplet	The sea temperature	Choosing your wetsuit
Circle with the weather	The air temperature and the weather icon (sun, clouds, rain…), the same as the watch's weather when you're near the spot. The **colour of the number is the sun (UV)**: white with no sun, green low, yellow moderate, orange high, red very high, violet extreme	Knowing whether you need sunscreen
Left subdial	The **waves**: big height (metres or feet) with the period below ("10s"). The little marker on the edge shows **where they come from**. Its colour tells you whether they reach your beach (see below)	Seeing the size and whether the swell arrives
Right subdial	The **wind**: speed (km/h or knots) and where it blows from ("SE"). The colour tells you whether it is offshore, cross-shore or onshore	Seeing whether the sea is clean
Date capsule	The day and the date. It moves out of the way by itself so the hands don't cover it	

Where	What it is	What it's for
Bottom curve	The **tide** for the next hours: the turquoise dots are high tides, the sand-coloured ones low tides, with their time. The little white triangle is now, with the current height below it	Knowing whether it is rising or falling and when it turns
Curved band	The name of the **spot**. A little turquoise dot on the left means you chose it yourself (fixed)	Knowing which spot the data is for
Teal hand (if you turned it on)	The **home time** while you travel, with a sun or a moon at its tip	Knowing the time at home without doing the maths. See Home time
Near the centre (in Digital, under the battery)	Only when something is up: "LOADING" (the spot's data hasn't arrived yet), "4 H AGO" in red (the data is hours old and the hourly forecast that was downloaded has already run out: the numbers turn grey; "2 D AGO" if it is days) or a crossed-out phone (the watch isn't connected to the phone)	Knowing whether the numbers are up to date

The colours

Colour	Waves (marker and period)	Wind (marker and letters)
Green	They come in head-on to the beach	Offshore: blows from the land, the sea stays clean
Yellow	They come in at an angle	Cross-shore: blows from the side
Red	They hit it from the side or from behind: the beach is blocked	Onshore: blows from the sea, chopping it up

Each spot knows which way its beach faces; that is what picks the colour.

Time in digits

In Customize → Time → **Digital**, the time goes big in the middle. Waves and wind move up to the top, the battery sits between the two, and the water and air go on either side of the date. The tide stays at the bottom and sunrise and sunset go at the very top.

Always on



When the screen is at rest (AMOLED displays with "always on" enabled on the watch), the face switches to a dark grey version that barely uses any battery: date, time and three rows with an icon: - **Waves:** height, period and where they come from. - **Wind:** speed and where it blows from. - **Tide:** the next one, with ▲ if it is high tide or ▼ if it is low tide, and its time.

Everything shifts a tiny bit every minute so the screen doesn't burn in. At rest the stale-data warning isn't shown.

Home time

When you travel, one more teal hand shows the time at home. It comes off: turn it on in Customize → **Home time**, or on the phone (Connect IQ app → Surf Dawn → Settings).

- **Where home is:** one of 21 cities from west to east, from Honolulu to Auckland (Montevideo, Buenos Aires, São Paulo, Santiago, Lima, Lisbon, Madrid, Bali, Sydney…), or **Here**, which keeps where the watch is at that moment: choose it at home before you leave. Each place is a position and the watch knows its time zone and daylight saving time, so the home time changes by itself when daylight saving starts or ends there. In the list, each city shows today's offset from UTC.
- **Home hand** (in Customize or on the phone):
  - **12 h · sun and moon** (default): it reads like the hour hand and reaches the hour markers, the ring with the least data. At its tip, a sun when it is day at home (6 to 18) or a moon at night.
  - **24 h · classic**: the classic GMT, one turn a day, pointing to a teal 24-hour scale that appears on the rim (24 at the top, 12 at the bottom). The rim darkens like a bezel, and the 12, 3, 6 and 9 become bars.
- **At home nothing changes:** when the watch is already on home time there is no hand and no scale.
- The date capsule keeps clear of the home hand too.
- **Time in digits:** instead of the hand, a little house and the home time in teal, under the battery (if there is a warning, such as LOADING, the warning goes there).
- **Always on:** the little house and the home time in grey, above the date.

Gestures: touch and hold

On watches with a touchscreen, touching and holding the face opens the other apps:

Where you hold	What opens
The water temperature	Session, to record a session (its Home screen tells you the wetsuit for that water)
The air temperature	The watch's weather
The battery	The watch's battery page
The band with the spot name	The spot picker in Forecast. The spot you choose also carries over to the face
The top row (sunrise and sunset)	inReach messages, if your watch offers them for watch faces; otherwise, Forecast
Anywhere else: waves, wind, tide	The day's Forecast

In Digital, the water and the air are the readings on either side of the date. If Session isn't installed, the water temperature opens Forecast. If Forecast isn't installed, holding the band moves on to the next spot in the same zone (and after the last one, to Automatic). On watches without a touchscreen, open Forecast and Session from the app list.

Customize

Hold **MENU** (the middle button on the left) → **Watch Face** → with Surf Dawn on screen, **START** → **Customize**:

Option	Values (defaults in bold)	What it changes
Spot	**Automatic** or a fixed spot	Automatic shows which one it is choosing ("Active · LA PLAGE"). Below are the 30 nearest spots from the zones the watch has, with their break type and distance. Choosing one makes it **fixed** until you go back to Automatic

Option	Values (defaults in bold)	What it changes
Zones	The watch's zones	How many spots each one has and whether it came with the face or was downloaded. Choosing a downloaded one deletes it (it asks for confirmation), including the one in use (the spot goes back to Automatic); it downloads itself again when you are there
Time	**Hands**, Digital	See Time in digits
Home time	**Off**, Here or one of 21 cities	One more hand with the time at home: see Home time. Below it says the city and the time there
Home hand	**12 h · sun and moon**, 24 h · classic	How the home time is shown
Background	**Sea**, Night, Graphite, Forest	The background colour. Graphite, nearly black, uses the least battery
Waves	**Total**, Swell	Total = the whole sea, the groundswell plus the wind waves (it is Windguru's "Wave" row). Swell = the groundswell only, with its period and direction
Height (waves and tide)	**Metres**, Feet	
Wind	**km/h**, Knots	
Version	(read only)	The installed version, the same as in the store ("1.7.1"). With "dev" at the end, it was loaded by cable

When you change spots, the data arrives in a few minutes; meanwhile you see "—" and "LOADING".

How it picks the spot

- Spots come in **zones** of up to 60 (Mar del Plata, Oahu's North Shore, Gold Coast, Mentawai…): over 2,000 spots in about 200 zones around the world. The face ships with Uruguay's, from Montevideo to Chuy: Canelones and Montevideo (Playa Honda, La Pantalla and the Costa de Oro, from El Pinar to Jaureguiberry), Maldonado (from Punta del Chileno to José Ignacio, with the Brava's numbered beach-access stops) and Rocha; **it downloads the rest by itself** when you arrive, Florianópolis and Praia do Rosa included: the first time in a new place it takes about 10 minutes (first it looks up which zones are there and then downloads yours) (you see "—" and "LOADING") and from then on it stays saved. It keeps up to 10 zones besides the built-in ones; when there is no room, it deletes the one you haven't used for the longest.
- It picks the **nearest one to where you are**, if it is less than 25 km away. It doesn't turn the GPS on: it uses the last location the watch has and checks it every 10 minutes. If you haven't done a GPS activity, that location is the one the phone passes to it and it can be far off (in Punta del Este it was once 19 km away): if the face shows a spot that isn't yours, open Session until the GPS turns green, and check that Garmin Connect has precise location on the phone.
- If you chose a **fixed** spot, it uses that one.
- If there is no spot nearby, it uses the **fallback spot**. By default it is La Plage. With the app installed from the store, you change it on the phone: Connect IQ app → Surf Dawn → Settings (name, latitude and longitude out at sea, and which way the beach faces, in degrees).
- If you chose, in Forecast, a spot from a zone the face doesn't have, it downloads the zone and then switches to that spot.
- Every update also downloads the data for the neighbouring spots in the zone (up to 8, within 25 km). That is why switching to a spot next door is instant. A distant one takes a few minutes: Garmin only allows background updates once every 5 minutes.
- Every three hours (or when the spot changes), the update also brings the **hourly forecast** for the spot in use for the next 30 hours (waves, wind, temperature and sky); the models run every six. Without the phone, the face steps forward to the current hour: at 15:00 it shows what was forecast for 15:00, even if the last download was from the morning. The numbers only turn grey when those hours run out.
- To download new data the watch needs the phone nearby with the Garmin Connect app.

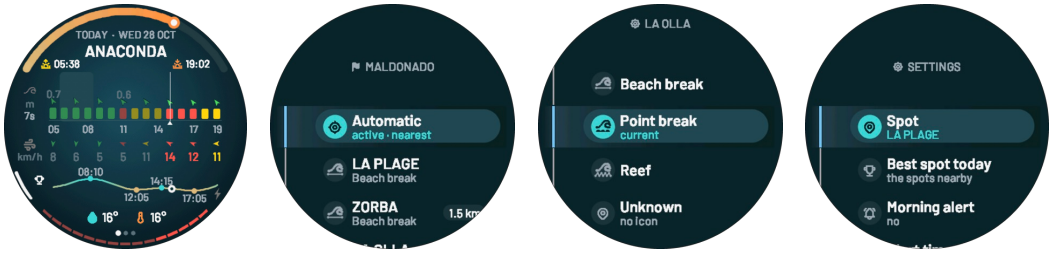
On other watches

- **MIP displays** (fēnix 7, Forerunner 955 and 255, fēnix 8 and 9 Pro Solar, Enduro 3): flat colours and no second hand. These watches' displays never turn off, so at rest you still see the full face.
- **Instinct Crossover AMOLED:** it has real hands, so the face draws neither its own hands nor the time in always-on mode, and it has neither the Time nor the Home hand option: the home time shows with the little house, near the centre.
- **Watches without a touchscreen** (Forerunner 255 and 255 Music, Instinct 3 AMOLED, Instinct Crossover AMOLED): they don't have the touch-and-hold gestures.

The full list is in Supported watches. Where each number comes from: Data and models.

Surf Dawn Forecast

Your spot's forecast for the day, hour by hour, on a single screen: waves, wind, tide, water and air, with the three best hours marked. It uses the same models as Windguru and the official tide tables. If you want, every morning it tells you which spot near you is the best one today (The morning alert).



Opening it

- From the Surf Dawn face: **press and hold the face** anywhere (outside the name band, the top row and the temperatures).
- From the face, holding the **name band**: opens the spot picker directly.
- From the watch's app list: "Surf Dawn Forecast".

When it opens it requests the data right away (it takes a second or two, with your phone nearby).

How to read it

From top to bottom:

1. **The day and the spot:** "TODAY · SAT 10 OCT" and the spot's name.
2. **Daylight:** the arc at the top runs from sunrise to sunset and fills up to the current time, with a little sun at the current time. Below its two ends, the sunrise and sunset times.
3. **The waves:** one bar per hour, from 5 to 19 h. Taller = bigger waves. Above the bars, the height wherever it changes. On the left, the unit and the period for the day ("10s", or "9-12s" if it changes).
    - **The bar's colour** is that hour's traffic light at your beach, like the bezel of Today: green if the swell comes in head-on and the wind is offshore, yellow if one of them is fair (diagonal or cross-shore), red if one doesn't work (blocked or onshore). If another swell comes in better at the beach, the traffic light goes by that one.
    - **The little arrows** above the bars (every two hours) point **where the waves are heading**, in the swell's own colour: green head-on, yellow diagonal, red from the side or from behind. Above it, a smaller **hollow** arrow is the other swell, when it matters; on those days the bars sit a little lower, so both arrows and the height fit.
    - Hours that have already passed look dimmer, and a white line with a little triangle marks the current hour.
4. **The best-hours band:** a box behind the three most favorable hours with daylight. See The best hours.
5. **The wind**, every two hours: an arrow showing where it blows toward and the speed, in green (offshore), yellow (cross-shore) or red (onshore).
6. **The tide:** the day's curve with the time of each high tide (turquoise dot) and low tide (sand dot), and a white dot at the current time.
7. **Water and air:** the current sea temperature (drop) and air temperature (thermometer); for tomorrow and the day after, the temperature at 8.
8. **The dots at the bottom:** which day you're on (today, tomorrow, the day after).
9. **The sea's energy**, on the lower bezel: one arc per hour, from 5 h on the left to 19 h on the right, wider and in its colour the more energy the waves bring (see The sea's energy). The bolt, on the right, says what it is.
10. **A trophy**, by the DOWN button: DOWN opens the Today page (in Spanish the word HOY fits there instead).

The sea's energy

Height alone fools you: 1 m of 4 s chop looks bigger on the bars than 0.7 m of 9 s swell, and breaks with far less power. The energy puts height and period in one number: the waves' energy per metre of crest, **1.96 × height² × period²**, in kJ, with the height and the period the page shows (Total or Swell, as set in Settings → Waves). 0.6 m and 7 s is 35 kJ; 1 m and 8 s, 126; 1.6 m and 12 s, 723.

Level	kJ	Colour	Bars
FLAT	under 25	grey	none
MINIMAL	25 to 60	red	1
LOW	60 to 150	orange	2
MEDIUM	150 to 300	yellow	3
GOOD	300 to 600	green	4
STRONG	600 to 1200	blue	5
BIG	from 1200	pink	6

On the Today page and on Session's Start it shows as a meter of six bars with the word. Other sites' kJ (surf-forecast, Surfline) may not match these: each works it out its own way.

The best hours

The box marks the three consecutive hours, with daylight, that look best. For each hour, the watch looks at:

- **The size** (counts most): nothing at 30 cm, best from 1.8 m.
- **The period:** nothing at 5 s, best from 13 s.
- **The wind:** it doesn't bother you up to a certain point, which depends on where it blows from: up to 35 km/h if offshore, 12 km/h if cross-shore and 8 km/h if onshore, changing little by little with the angle in between. Stronger than that, the hour is worth less and less.
- **Whether the waves reach the beach:** head-on ones count in full, diagonal ones a bit less, blocked ones much less, also little by little with the angle: two beaches facing a few degrees apart don't tie, and neither jumps suddenly past the other.
- **Each spot's shelter:** the watch knows on which sides each spot has land nearby (worked out from the OpenStreetMap coastline). Wind that crosses land less than 2 km away raises almost no chop (El Emir in a southwest wind, behind the peninsula), and swell with a headland or an island in the way arrives cut.
- **The other swell:** if there is an other swell, each hour is worth what the one that comes in better at the beach is worth, the page's waves or that one.

If the day has nothing worthwhile, the box doesn't appear. This calculation is the same for everyone; the stars based on your own sessions are in Session.

The other swell

The sea often comes from two sides at once: in Uruguay, an east sea and a south swell; in Hawaii, the north swell and the trade-wind swell. A beach blocked from one may get the other. The wave model (GFS Wave) splits the sea into the wind chop and up to three swells, biggest first, and the watch looks at the two biggest: **the other swell** is the bigger of those two that comes from another side (30° or more away from the waves the page shows) and is at least 30 cm.

It is drawn **only when it matters**: when it is the one that comes in better at your beach (and then it decides the colour and the best hours) or when it brings at least half the energy of the page's waves. That way it shows in few hours: over a month in 29 zones, in 4 % (drawn whenever there is another swell, in 30 %).

- **On the page:** a smaller, hollow arrow above the swell's (every two hours), in its colour: green if it comes in head-on at your beach, yellow diagonal, red blocked.
- **On Today:** a short arrow in from the edge of the rose, with its height and period next to it ("0.6 m 10 s").
- **In the score:** each hour is worth what the one that comes in better at the beach is worth, the page's waves or the other swell, and the bar's colour, Today's bezel, the best-hours band and the morning alert go by that one. For example, on 23 October at Cabo Polonio (facing south) the east sea came in from the side, red all day; the 10 s southeast swell came in diagonally, and the day turns yellow.

The order of the model's swells changes during the day (the first one becomes the second when another grows), so the hollow arrow can jump sides from one hour to the next. A third swell hardly ever changes anything: over a month in 26 zones around the world, adding it changed the best spot on a single day. In the zones with the ECMWF WAM model (California, Hawaii except Oahu's

North Shore, the US Northeast, southwest Ireland) there is no separate swell and it doesn't appear.

Changing the day

Swipe left to see tomorrow and the day after, and right to go back. After 19 h it opens straight on tomorrow.

On watches without a touchscreen (Forerunner 255, Instinct 3 AMOLED, Instinct Crossover AMOLED) only the first day is shown.

Choosing the spot

UP or a tap on the screen open the spot picker (**DOWN** opens the Today page).

- It opens on the **zone** you're in (for example "Maldonado" or "North Shore de Oahu"), with **Automatic** always at the top (it says which one is the nearest, or "nearest to where you are" if you're far from the spots; if it's the one in use, it says "active") and the spots from nearest to farthest. Each one shows its distance and a little arrow pointing to where it is (with north up).
- **BACK** shows the folders:
  - **The zone in use**, with how many spots it has.
  - **Saved zones**: the ones the watch has (the factory ones, which are Uruguay's, and the downloaded ones). Inside a downloaded one, the last row, **Remove this zone**, deletes it (it asks for confirmation), even the one in use: the picker goes back to Automatic and the zone downloads itself again when you're there.
  - **The whole world**: continent → country → region. Each region says how many spots it has and whether it's already saved or how much it weighs to download (2 or 3 KB). Choosing it downloads it and opens it.
- When you arrive somewhere new, the app downloads that zone on its own.
- When you pick a spot, its forecast is downloaded and **the Surf Dawn face switches to that same spot** (if it doesn't have that zone, it downloads it). Automatic goes back to picking the nearest one.
- Each app keeps its own zones (up to 10 besides the factory ones): when there's no room, the one you haven't used for the longest goes, and the ones you downloaded by hand go last.

Break type. The icon on each spot tells you how it breaks:

Icon	Type
The wave over a line of sand	Beach break (sand bottom)
The wave over three round stones	Point break (breaks against a point)
The wave over a row of teeth	Reef (rock or reef bottom)
A pin	Unknown

If you disagree with a spot's type, the last row of the picker, **Break type**, changes it: pick the spot and then Beach break, Point break, Reef or Unknown. It's marked "edited", and **As shipped** puts it back to the original. The change stays in Forecast only: Session and the face have their own.

The morning alert



Every day when you wake up (that's how it comes out of the box) or at the time you choose, the watch vibrates with **the best spot to surf today** among the ones near you: "Today: EL EMIR", and below it the waves and period in the day's best window ("1.4 m 6 s · 07-09 h") and the next two spots ("Next: …"). If other spots are about as good, it says "As good: LA PLAGE, ZORBA" (and "+3" if there are more).

- **How it picks:** it compares the nearest spots of your zone (up to 12, within 25 km of where you were the last time you closed the app; if the watch didn't know where you were, of the spot in use). For each one it finds its best three daylight hours, with the same scoring as The best hours, and the best window wins; on a tie, the nearest spot. Less than 15 % apart counts as about as good: the models miss the wind by about 5 km/h and 15°, and that alone moves the score that much. With the same swell, what usually decides is which way each beach faces and how the wind hits it.
- **Fresh data:** at the alert's time the watch asks for the forecast right then (the models' latest run), with the phone nearby or over Wi-Fi or LTE.
- **Without a connection, last night's:** at 21:00 the watch gets the next day's ranking (the phone is still there, before a sleep mode with battery saver turns it off). If there is no connection at the alert's time, it alerts with that one, marked "last night", and keeps trying every 15 minutes for four hours, and also as soon as the sleep mode schedule ends. When it gets the new forecast, it alerts again if the best spot, the window or the day's colour changed; if it's the same, it doesn't.
- **The icon's star** tells how the day looks: **green** if it's good (3 stars or more), **yellow** if it's fair.
- **A weak day doesn't alert:** if no spot has a window worth it (the forecast shows no band), the watch doesn't vibrate or show the notification, but the glance and the Today page still show the best there is, in red.
- **Open the alert** (**Open**) to see the Today page.
- **It stays on the glance:** the watch doesn't keep app notifications in the notification center, so the best spot stays in view all day on Forecast's glance (scrolling down from the watch face): the spot and its window in a pill the colour of the day; a bar with the hours from 05 to 19 in the colours of the Today page's bezel, the window's three taller and a mark at the time now; and below, the waves, the wind (with an arrow where it blows) and "last night" while it is still the evening's. After 19:00, once it has tomorrow's, it shows tomorrow's. Selecting it opens the Today page.
- It alerts once a day (twice if it alerted with last night's and the new one changed). If the watch is in sleep mode or Do Not Disturb at that time, it may not vibrate (it depends on how you have it set up); it stays on the glance anyway.
- **If it didn't come,** Settings → **Last try** says when it last tried and how it went: "notified", "weak day" (it got the forecast and didn't alert because the day is no good), "-104 no phone" (it couldn't find the phone over Bluetooth), "no answer", "out of memory", "no spots" (open and close Forecast once) or another error code. If it shows an earlier day, it didn't even try at the alert time. Only the last try is kept.
- **Turning it on or off:** on the watch, Settings (hold **UP**) → **Morning alert**, and the time in **Alert time** (06:00 to 09:00, every 15 minutes, or **At wake time**; each START moves to the next one). Also from the Connect IQ app on the phone, in Surf Dawn Forecast's settings; if you turn it on there, open Forecast once on the watch so it gets scheduled. It comes on, at wake time: it gets scheduled the first time you close Forecast.
- **At wake time:** the alert comes when the watch's sleep schedule ends, each day's own: if you wake up later on Saturdays, that day it alerts later. Watches with Connect IQ 6 (like the fēnix 9) know the time for each day of the week; the others use the wake time in your profile, the same every day, and if the watch knows none, it alerts at 06:00. Settings says when the next one comes ("at wake time · 06:45"). The sleep schedule is changed on the watch or in Garmin Connect.
- **Why not a few minutes earlier:** until then the watch is in sleep mode, in Do Not Disturb and, with battery saver, without the phone, and app notifications are not kept: an alert before you wake up could go by without you seeing it. At that time it asks for the forecast, which takes a few seconds; if the phone isn't back yet, it alerts with last night's and carries on as always.
- **When updating from the store,** Garmin Connect may ask you to accept Forecast's new permissions: background (to fetch the forecast at that time with the app closed), notifications and user profile (to know when you wake up).

The Today page

It opens with **DOWN** from the forecast, when you open the alert, or from Settings → **Best spot today**. After 19:00 it shows tomorrow.

- **Which spot:** from the alert, the glance or Settings, the day's best ("BEST SPOT"); from the forecast, the spot you were looking at, with its place among the ones compared ("5 OF 12 SPOTS"). If that spot wasn't compared, the best.
- **The bezel is the day, from 05 to 20,** one segment per hour, a traffic light of the swell and the wind at that beach at that hour, in the colours of their arrows: green if the swell comes in head-on and the wind is offshore, yellow if one of them is fair (diagonal or cross-shore), red if one doesn't work (blocked or onshore); the worse of the two wins. If another swell comes in better at the beach, that is the swell of the traffic light. The best window comes from the score, which also weighs the size, the period and how strong the wind is, so it can fall on yellow hours (a cross-shore but light wind, for example). A green halo marks the best window and the white dot, the time now.
- **The hour you're looking at** has a white rim on its bezel segment and, next to it, **NOW** (the current one) or the hour ("15 h"). It opens on the current one; **DOWN** goes to the next and **UP** to the one before, and on touchscreen watches a tap on the bezel jumps to that hour.

- **Inside, for that hour:** the spot and its stars (the forecast's; the ones from your history are in Session); the **spot's rose**: your beach seen from above with the sea up, the sand at the bottom and you on the shore, with the swell (thick arrow) and the wind (thin arrow with feathers) coming in from where they come from, in the usual colours, and the other swell, if it matters, as a short arrow in from the edge, with its height and period next to it; below, on the left, **the waves** from the average wave to the sets ("0.4–0.6 m": the forecast's height is the average of the highest third, so most waves are smaller) with the period above; on the right, **the wind** with where it blows from above; and under both, centred and big, the energy.
- **A weak day** says "WEAK DAY" in red, with empty red stars.
- **At the bottom, the other spots:** the second and the third, or, if the spot isn't the best, the best and the next one ("1 LA BOCA · 6 ZORBA").
- **Spots nearby:** with **UP held** or a tap on the line of the other spots, the spots compared from best to worst, each with its window (or "weak"), a bar showing how good it is and its stars (red if it's weak).
- **START** (or picking one in Spots nearby) opens that spot's forecast, without changing the spot you picked or the face's. **BACK** goes back to the forecast.
- If the alert already downloaded the day's data less than three hours ago, it shows it without asking; otherwise it asks for it (without a connection, START retries).

On other watch faces

Surf Dawn Forecast publishes three complications for the spot you use. They show on Face It (the watch faces you build from a photo in the Connect IQ app on the phone), on Connect IQ watch faces that take other apps' complications and in the preview of glance folders. Garmin's own watch faces don't show other apps' complications.

Complication	What it shows	For example
Best hours (star)	the day's best three daylight hours and their stars, the same as the band and the alert; once they're over, the best of what's left, or "weak" when it doesn't work; at night, tomorrow's	06-08 4/5
Waves now (the wave)	from the mean wave to the sets, as on Today	1.1-1.7 m
Wind now (wind)	the wind's class at the beach (offshore, cross-shore or onshore) and its speed, rounded to 5 km/h or 2 knots, without the unit	offshore 10

- **To add them:** in Face It, when you build the face, pick "Surf Dawn Best hours", "Surf Dawn Waves now" or "Surf Dawn Wind now". On a Connect IQ watch face, from its settings; there the best hours may show up as "Surf Dawn Pronóstico". The colour comes from the face.
- **They update on their own:** every time you open Surf Dawn Forecast and, without opening it, once a day in the early morning, when the watch asks for the spot's forecast through the phone. Without the phone they keep the last one they got, for up to two days; then they show "–". The hours are the spot's.
- **Holding** a complication, on faces that allow it, opens Surf Dawn Forecast.
- **To turn them off:** Settings → Complications, or Surf Dawn Forecast's settings in the Connect IQ app on the phone. Off, they're left empty and the watch asks for nothing for them.

Buttons

Button	What it does
UP or a tap	Spot picker
DOWN or a swipe up	Today page
Swipe sideways	Change day
START	Request the data again
UP held (MENU)	Settings

Button	What it does
BACK	Exit (returns to the face)

Forecast settings

Setting	Values (factory default in bold)
Spot	opens the picker
Best spot today	opens the Today page
Morning alert	**Yes** or No (The morning alert)
Alert time	06:00 to 09:00, every 15 minutes, or **At wake time**
Last try	how the alert went last time (shows up after the first try)
Complications	**Yes** or No (On other watch faces)
Waves	**Total** (the whole sea) or Swell (only the groundswell)
Height	**Metres** or Feet
Wind	**km/h** or Knots
Background	**Sea**, Night, Graphite or Forest (each START moves to the next one)
Language	**Match the watch**, Español, English or Português: the app's, the alert's, the glance's and the complications' (Languages)
Rate this app	opens Surf Dawn Forecast's page in the Connect IQ store on your phone, to leave a review ("no phone" if it is not connected)
Version	the installed version, the same as in the store (with "dev" at the end, loaded by cable)

You have to set them here too: Garmin doesn't let one app read another's settings. The factory defaults are the same in all three. The alert, its time and the complications can also be changed from the Connect IQ app on the phone.

No connection

If it can't download the data, it shows the latest data it downloaded for this spot: at the top, in place of the date, it says since when, in orange, **"AS OF 07:10"** if it's from today, **"YESTERDAY 07:10"** or **"AS OF SAT 07:10"** if it's older. Forecasts cover three days, so yesterday's still has today and tomorrow, and one from the day before yesterday only has today (the dots at the bottom show how many days are left). As soon as the connection returns they update on their own when you open the app, or with **START**. If a retry fails, it goes back to showing the saved ones.

If there's no data for this spot that reaches today (the latest is three or more days old, or is from another spot), it shows "NO CONNECTION" in red. Check that your phone is nearby with Garmin Connect open and press **START** to retry.

Besides the spot in use, each app keeps the last forecast of the **two spots you used before**: when you go back to one it shows up right away (with since when, as above) while the new one downloads, also without a connection. They're the first thing deleted if the watch needs room.

Each app keeps its own forecast: what Forecast downloaded isn't seen by Session, and the other way around (Garmin doesn't let one app read another's data). To have it at the beach without your phone, open the app you're going to use before you leave.

Where each number comes from and why those models: Data and models.

Surf Dawn Session

Session records your surf session and saves it to Garmin Connect as a **Surfing** activity. It counts your waves on its own, tells you which way to go in the water and, when you get out, shows you a summary. With the stars you give each session, it learns which conditions you like at each spot.



To open it: press and hold the water temperature on the Surf Dawn face, or find it in the watch's app list ("Surf Dawn Session"). It opens on the **Home** screen.

Before you go in: the Home screen

Home shows you how the sea is right now at your spot, and whether the watch is ready to record.



Where	What it is	What it's for
In the middle	The time, the spot and the **GPS**: a grey ring while it looks for a signal, a green check when it's ready to record	Wait for the green before pressing START
Left subdial	**The waves:** from the average wave to the sets ("0.4–0.6 m": the forecast's height is the average of the highest third, most waves are smaller), what their direction means on this beach (**head-on** green, **angled** yellow, **blocked** red) and the sea's energy in seven levels. Its rim is the **spot's rose**: the spot seen from above with the sea at the top (as on the map of the waves), the sand at the bottom with you on the shore (the white dot) and the arrow from where the waves come	Know whether there are waves, how much power they have, and whether they reach your beach well
Right subdial	**The wind:** speed and whether it's **offshore** (green, blowing from the land), **cross-shore** (yellow) or **onshore** (red), with the same rose on the rim and the arrow from where it blows. At a spot with no facing, the rose keeps north at the top and instead of the words it says where they come from (SE, S…)	Know whether the sea is clean or choppy

Where	What it is	What it's for
Top subdial	**The tide:** the height now and the next high or low ("falling 15:35"). Its rim is a tide clock: high at the top (teal), low at the bottom (sand), falling down the right and rising up the left, with a white dot at the moment of the cycle	Pick when to go in
Bottom subdial	**The water:** degrees (from the forecast) and its temperature on the rim, and the recommended wetsuit: the thickness and below it the icons for boots, gloves and hood when needed	Know what to wear

Start is how the sea is now: the whole day (the day's tide, the best hours, the sunset) is in the conditions, with **UP**.

No connection: if it can't download the forecast, it shows the last one it downloaded for this spot (in this app: open it before you head out), with the waves and wind **in grey**, even if it's from yesterday or the day before (it covers three days). The conditions (UP) say since when: "AS OF 07:10", "YESTERDAY 07:10" or "AS OF SAT 07:10". Without a forecast for the spot that reaches today, waves and wind stay as "–" and the conditions say "NO CONNECTION". The session records either way.

Buttons on Home

Button	What it does
START	Starts the session
UP	Shows or hides the day's conditions (the same page as Forecast, with your stars over the best hours). There, swiping sideways changes the day, and START closes them or, if they say "NO CONNECTION", downloads the forecast again
DOWN	Opens the menu: the routines, apnea (the test and the CO2 and O2 tables) and Settings
Hold UP (MENU)	Settings
BACK	Closes the app (or closes the conditions, if they're open)

The spot. Session picks the nearest spot on its own. With the first good GPS fix it switches to the one nearest to where you really are. If you picked one by hand (Settings → Spot), it keeps it as long as you're within 5 km of it. The picker is the same as in Forecast, with the wave over sand, rocks or reef according to the break type. Each app keeps its own spot: choosing one here doesn't change it on the face or in Forecast.

The recommended wetsuit

At the bottom you'll see the wetsuit for today's water: the thickness as text and, when needed, icons for **boots**, **gloves** and **hood**. The watch doesn't just look at the water:

- With wind of 20 to 29 km/h, it counts the water as one degree colder; with 30 km/h or more (strong wind), two degrees.
- If the air is more than 4 °C colder than the water, one more degree.

Water (already adjusted for wind and air)	Wetsuit	Boots	Gloves	Hood
24 °C or more	rash guard			
21 to 24 °C	shorty			
17 to 21 °C	3/2			
15 to 17 °C	4/3			with strong wind
13 to 15 °C	4/3	✓		with strong wind

Water (already adjusted for wind and air)	Wetsuit	Boots	Gloves	Hood
10 to 13 °C	5/4	✓	✓	✓
less than 10 °C	6/5	✓	✓	✓

It's a guide: each wetsuit brand shifts the cut-offs by a degree or two.

Routines: Pre-surf, Post-surf and CO2 table

DOWN on Home opens the menu: **Pre-surf**, **Post-surf**, **Apnea** and **Settings** (the same as UP held). **Apnea** opens the apnea test, the **CO2 table** and the O2 table, each with its own line under it (your best, how long you hold and how long it takes); BACK there goes back to the menu. UP and DOWN choose, START starts and BACK goes back to Home. They're meant for home: Pre-surf before you go, Post-surf when you're back. Each one is saved in Garmin Connect as an activity: Pre-surf and Post-surf as **Flexibility training** and the tables as **Breathwork**, with a lap per exercise, the time and the heart rate. If you leave with BACK before the first minute it isn't saved; after that, what you did is. A phone notification over the screen doesn't cut it: it stays one activity. Routines don't use GPS: it turns off when one starts and looks for a signal again back on Home, so the activity doesn't keep where you did it.



Routine	How long	What's in it
Pre-surf	5 min	Cat Camel ×6, Bird Dog ×6, Lunge with twist ×3 per side, Arm circles 0:30, Heel raises ×15, Stance squat ×8, Pop-up ×5
Post-surf	10 min	Cat Camel ×6 in 30 s, Doorway chest, Kneeling lat stretch, Open book, Hip flexor, Standing quad, Figure-4 glute, Hamstrings with band and Wall calf stretch (1 min each, 45 s the lats), Neck ×10 in 30 s and 4-6 breathing 1:00
CO2 table	14 min	2 min of easy nasal breathing, 6 holds of 30 s with 1:30 of breathing between them, and 1 min of 4-6 breathing
O2 table	21 min	The same with 6 holds growing from 45 % to 80 % of your best and 2:00 of breathing between them (with a best of 2:06)

Everything looks after your back: no loaded bending, a neutral spine, and the movement comes from the hips and the upper back. The lower back isn't stretched (no knees to the chest): after paddling it moves with the Cat Camel, gently and in a comfortable range.

Each exercise is one screen: a figure doing the movement, back and forth (orange is what moves; in the arm circles it goes round, and halfway it turns the other way), the name, the reps or the time, and a cue at the bottom. The bezel has a segment per exercise: teal the ones done and orange the current one, filling with its time. The stance squat and the pop-up are drawn in your stance (Settings → **Stance**): for a goofy the nose of the board is on the right and for a regular, on the left; in both, the back arm is on the far side of the body, a little lower.

- **With reps** ("6 times", "3 per side"): when you're done, START goes to the next one.

- **With time** ("1:00"): it waits with "START starts", so you can get in position. With START the countdown runs ("0:18 / 1:00"), it moves on by itself with a vibration at the end, and START skips it. The ones done per side vibrate twice halfway and say "side 2" (arm circles say "now backwards").
- **At a pace** (Post-surf's Cat Camel and neck): they also wait for START and then move on by themselves. The figure sets the pace, once per back and forth, and the number says which one you're on ("4 / 10").
- **4-6 breathing:** a ring with the 10 s cycle, 4 to breathe in in teal and 6 to breathe out in lilac, and a dot going round it; the part you're on lights up and the other dims. In the middle, the teal nose while breathing in and the lilac wind while breathing out (the wind crossed out is holding, in the tables). At the bottom it says "breathe in through the nose" or "breathe out slowly", in the same colour, and the watch vibrates at each change: one long vibration to breathe in, two short ones to breathe out.
- **The screen:** it turns on at each change (exercise, side, breathing in or out) and every 10 seconds. AMOLED watches don't let an app keep it on for more than a minute in a row, so it may still go dark for a moment. With the watch's **Touch Lock** on (in its display settings), each time it goes dark the touchscreen locks: swipe down to unlock it. The buttons always work, in the apnea test too.
- BACK goes back to Home at any time.

At the end **Done** shows the exercises and the time ("IN GARMIN CONNECT": it's already saved), and after 4 seconds it goes back to Home by itself.



CO2 table: it trains bearing the CO2, what you feel in a long hold-down. The crossed-out wind is **Hold**, with an orange ring filling with the seconds; between holds, the nose is **Breathe**. At the end it asks "How did it go?": **Easy** makes the next one 5 s longer to hold (up to 1 min, or half your apnea test best if that's longer) and then 10 s shorter to rest (down to 1 min); **Hard** gives the rest back first and then shortens the hold (not under 20 s); **Just right** keeps it the same. Each option says what the next one will be.

> **Always on dry land**, seated or lying down, never in the water or driving. Before a hold, a normal breath in: hyperventilating is what causes blackouts. Stop at the first strong urge to breathe.

Apnea test

The test measures the longest breath hold you can do, **on dry land**: your best, how your heart rate drops while you hold and how long the calm part lasts, before the first contraction. With the result, the CO2 table fits you.

Opening it: DOWN on Home, **Apnea** (your best is under it) and **Apnea test**, with START. The first time you get the **On dry land** warning: sitting or lying down, never in the water, no hyperventilating first and better with someone near; START accepts it and begins. From the second test on you get the **history** instead: your best, how many tests you did, the last easy part and the curve of the last 8. START begins, BACK goes back to Home.



Step	How long	What you do
Get ready	1:50	4-6 breathing, the same as at the end of Post-surf

Step	How long	What you do
Breathe in and hold	10 s	The countdown in the ring: one normal breath in, no hyperventilating
Hold	as long as you can	The watch buzzes at the start and counts. START ends it

While you hold: the time at the top, and the bezel fills once a minute. In the middle, your heart rate's curve: it usually drops when you hold (the diving reflex), and below it says by how much. When you feel the **first contraction** (the diaphragm pushing to breathe), press **DOWN**: the strip at the bottom turns from teal to orange, and the hold is split into the **easy part** and the **struggle**. When you pass your best it buzzes three times. The screen turns on again every 10 s (AMOLED watches don't keep it on more than a minute in a row). BACK leaves without saving the test.

The result: the time and how it went against your best ("best · +14 s"), the bar of the easy part and the struggle, your heart rate at the start and the lowest, and **SpO2** at the start and the end if the watch measures it (on the wrist it's slow: in a hold of 1 or 2 minutes it hardly changes). If you marked the contraction, it says how much the easy part grew or dropped since the last test that had it; if not, it reminds you to mark it next time. A hold under 10 s (START by mistake) isn't saved.

The CO2 table from the test: with START, if half the test changes the CO2 table's hold by 5 s or more, it asks "Set it to your 2:06?": **Yes** sets it to half (1:03) and **No** leaves it as it is. After that, Easy and Hard keep adjusting it, and with a best the top for Easy is half your best instead of 1 min.

The test is saved in Garmin Connect as **Breathwork** ("Apnea test"), with the heart rate, a lap per step and another from the contraction. The history keeps the last 20 tests.

> **Always on dry land**, seated or lying down, never in the water or driving: a long hold can end in a blackout with no warning, and in the water that kills. Before a hold, a normal breath in: hyperventilating gives you no more air and makes a blackout more likely.

O2 table

The O2 table trains bearing little oxygen: the closest thing to staying under a set. The CO2 table has short holds and rests that shrink; the O2 table, the other way round: the rest stays the same and the holds grow up to near your longest. They come from your best in the apnea test.

Opening it: DOWN on Home, **Apnea** and **O2 table** (under it, how far it goes and how long it takes: "up to 1:41 · 21 min"), with START. Without any test it says "the test first", and START opens the test with its warning.



Step	How long (best 2:06)	What you do
Easy nasal	2:00	Breathe through your nose, calmly
Hold ×6	0:57, 1:06, 1:14, 1:23, 1:32 and 1:41	From 45 % to 80 % of your best, a longer one each round
Breathe ×5	2:00	Between holds, through your nose, without loading up on air
4-6 breathing	1:00	To finish

The screens are the CO2 table's: "O2 · ROUND 5/6" at the top, the bezel with a segment per round and, under each hold, which part of your best it is ("73 % of your best"). It runs by itself: each step moves on with a vibration and START skips it.

At the end, "How did it go?": **Easy** raises the top 5 % (up to 85 % of your best), **Hard** lowers it 5 % (down to 70 %) and **Just right** keeps it; each option says how far the next one goes ("next: up to 1:47"). Since it comes from your best, a new best in the test raises the table by itself.

It's saved in Garmin Connect as **Breathwork** ("O2 table"), with the heart rate and a lap per step.

> **Always on dry land**, seated or lying down, never in the water or driving. The O2 table is harder than the CO2 one: long holds one after another, with less oxygen each time. Between them breathe calmly, without hyperventilating, and if a hold doesn't come, START cuts it.

Starting

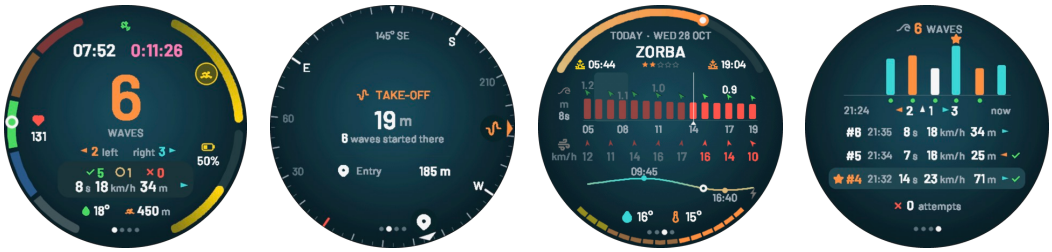
1. Wait for the satellite to turn **green**.
2. Press **START**. The watch vibrates and moves to the Session page.

If there's no GPS yet, START shows the "No GPS" notice. If you still want to start, press **START again**: it records without a position until the GPS shows up.

Tips: - On the watch, set **Display → During activity → Always on**, so you can see it without touching anything. - On a beach that isn't in any zone, press START at the shoreline: with the first metres you paddle, the watch learns which way the beach lies. At spots inside the zones it already knows. - The first minute of the session never counts as a wave.

In the water: the four pages

DOWN goes to the next page and UP to the previous one: **Session → Take-off → Forecast → Waves** and back to Session. If you stay on Forecast or Waves, after 30 seconds it returns to Session on its own. Take-off doesn't return on its own: it stays while you follow the arrow.



Session page

- **Very top, between the two bezels:** the GPS right now: the satellite in **green** (there's a position), **yellow** (weak position) or **red** (no position coming through, for example with your wrist under the water).
- **Top:** the time and, in pink, the session time (pauses don't count).
- **Middle, large:** the waves you've caught so far and, below, how many were lefts (◂ **orange**) and rights (**teal** ▶), in the Waves page's colours.
- **The card below:** the **last wave** (how many seconds it lasted, the top speed, the metres and which way it went) and, on top, how long ago it ended ("LAST · 3 min ago").
- **In Calibrate mode** (as it comes), the top of the card shows your marks instead of how long ago: green ✓ **good** (you marked it and the watch counted it), sand ○ **missed** (you marked it and the watch didn't see it), red ✗ **extra** (the watch counted one you didn't mark). See Marking waves.
- **Bottom, the water and the paddling:** the temperature the watch measures (it shows up after 8 minutes of session, once the sensor has stopped feeling the heat from your wrist) and, next to the swimmer, how far you have paddled: in metres up to 1 km and then in kilometres, or in yards and miles if the waves are in feet (Settings → Height). See How waves are counted.
- **Left bezel:** your heart rate. The zone you're in lights up (grey, blue, green, orange, red) and next to it go the heart and the beats per minute. With no pulse, or below zone 1, all five stay off.
- **Right bezel, top:** what you're doing, with a colour and an icon: clock = waiting, swimmer = paddling, wave = riding, diver = duck diving, pause = session paused.
- **Right bezel, bottom:** the battery (green, yellow or red).

Take-off page: the compass

It takes you back to the place where your waves break.

- **The ring** is a compass that turns with the watch (the N is in red). At the top it says which way the watch is pointing, for example "138° SE". On watches without a compass (which ones) the ring turns with the direction you're moving; when you're still, after 10 seconds it settles with north at the top and the top just says "N".
- **Two markers on the edge**, each one where its place is: the **orange wave** is the **take-off zone** (the place where you caught today's waves) and the **white pin** is the **entry** (where you started the session). Each marker has a notch that points outward.
- **In the middle**, with the same orange wave: how many metres you are from the take-off and how many waves started there. **At the bottom**, with the same pin: the metres to the entry.
- **Before your first wave**, if you've already surfed that spot, the wave marks the zone from an earlier session (in sand colour): the last one at the same tide (rising or falling), and the bottom says "from your sessions at this tide"; if you've never gone at this tide, the one from your last session there, and it says "from your last session here". If you've never surfed that spot, it says "shows up with the first wave".
- If a marker ends up right behind you, it shifts a little along the edge so it doesn't cover the page dots.
- **The current**, when the watch has measured it: a turquoise arc on the edge toward where it's carrying you, and the row "Current 0.3 m/s". See Current and drift.
- **The swell period** you feel sitting on the board (the stopwatch), next to the one the forecast gives: "Period 11 s · fcst 10".

Distances are always in metres and the current in metres per second.

Forecast page

The conditions: the spot's forecast for the day, as in Forecast, with **your stars** over the three best hours. You can't change day while recording. If it couldn't be downloaded, it shows the last one downloaded with since when at the top ("AS OF 07:10", "YESTERDAY 07:10"), or says "NO CONNECTION" if there's none for the spot that reaches today: while recording, START opens the menu, so to retry, end the session and press START on the conditions in Home.

Waves page

- **The timeline** of the session: one bar per wave, taller the longer it lasted. **Orange** = left, **turquoise** = right, **white** = straight. The **star** marks the best wave of the day, and a green dot, the ones you marked.
- **How many** went left, straight and right.
- **The last three waves:** time, seconds, top speed, metres and which way. The best one is highlighted.
- **Attempts:** the waves you paddled for and didn't catch.

The **best wave** is the one that adds up the most between how long it lasted, how fast it was and the manoeuvres you did.

Buttons in the water

Button	What it does
START	Opens the menu without pausing the session
BACK once	Nothing. That way your wetsuit cuff doesn't kick you out of the app or mark waves by accident
BACK twice in a row	Marks a wave (in Calibrate mode). The watch vibrates twice
UP / DOWN	Previous / next page
Hold UP (MENU)	Settings (the ones you can change in the water)
Hold LIGHT	The watch's controls menu (light, inReach messages, SOS). The session keeps recording
Touchscreen	Does nothing with the session open (recording, paused and on the summary, also in the START menu, Rate and Tags), unless you turn on "Touch in session" in Settings. Settings and the Discard confirmation are watch screens and respond to touch

Vibrations: one at the start, a short one every time the watch counts a wave (when it ends, not when you stand up), two short ones when you mark, a long one with each alert and two when saving.

The START menu



START opens the menu without pausing. UP and DOWN choose, START confirms and BACK closes it. If you don't touch anything, it closes on its own after 20 seconds ("closes in 15 s").

Option	What it does
Continue	Goes back to the session (if it was paused, resumes it)
Mark wave	Same as BACK twice (only if marking is on)
Pause / Resume	Pauses the time and the detection, or turns them back on
Waves	The list of all your waves, newest to oldest: seconds, top speed, metres, which way, **strokes** to catch it and **manoeuvres**; the selected wave (UP and DOWN) also shows its **pop-up** and whether it was **frontside** or **backside**. The best one has a star
Save	Ends the session and shows the summary
Discard	Deletes the session (asks for confirmation)
Mode	Switches from Calibrate to Automatic and back

To finish: START, UP three times to **Save**, and START.

How waves are counted

The watch uses the GPS, accelerometer and gyroscope in your wrist:

- **A wave** starts when you head toward the beach at more than 7 km/h for a couple of seconds (or with the drop and jolt typical of a take-off on a wave with a wall). It counts if it lasts at least 3 seconds, reaches 10 km/h and covers at least 10 metres. Between one wave and the next, 15 seconds have to pass. These numbers are those of the **Wall** detection, the factory default; in Settings you can choose another.
- **An attempt** is a strong paddle toward a wave that doesn't end up as a wave. They're counted separately.
- **Caught** = waves out of waves plus attempts. If you paddled for 9 and caught 6, it's 6/9 (66 %).
- **Left or right** is seen from the board, facing the beach: if the wave took you toward your right it's a right. If you went straight to the shore, it's "straight".
- **Frontside or backside** comes from the direction and your stance (Settings → **Stance**, Goofy by default): facing the wave (frontside) are the lefts for a goofy and the rights for a regular; the others are backside. A "straight" wave is neither.
- **Manoeuvres:** within a wave, each sharp turn of the wrist (measured by the gyroscope) or each change of direction of more than 60° that the GPS sees counts as a manoeuvre, at most one every 3 seconds. If you turn off the gyroscope in Settings, only changes of direction count.
- **Strokes:** the watch picks up the rhythm of your paddling on your wrist. For each wave it counts the strokes in the 15 seconds before (how much you paddled to catch it). It also adds up those of the whole session.
- **Metres paddled:** the time you paddled times your paddling speed. While you paddle, your wrist goes into the water on every stroke and the GPS gets a position only now and then, so the watch does not add up the track point by point: it measures your speed over the stretches where it sees you paddle between two positions and multiplies it by the time

spent paddling. The speed is yours with that board: it starts from your previous sessions with it (1 m/s with a new board) and adjusts to what it measures during the session. It is an estimate: good for comparing sessions, not for measuring a distance.

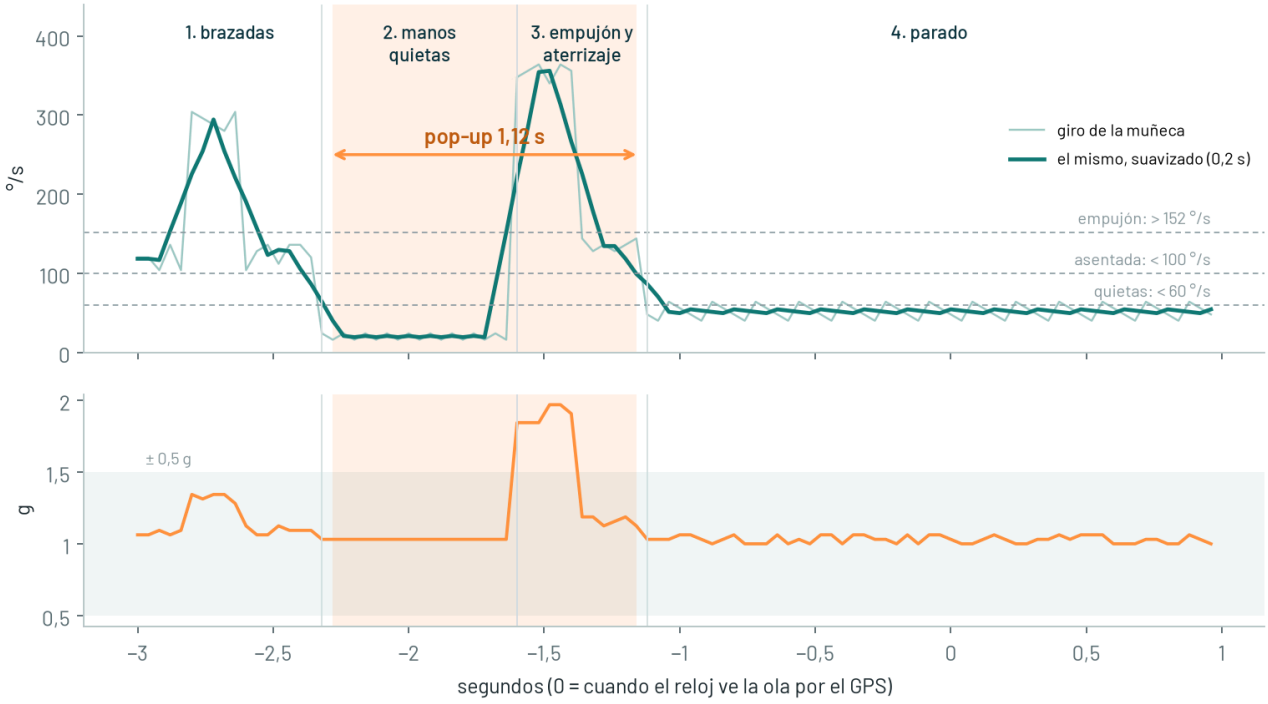
- **Pop-up:** the time it takes you to stand up, measured with the wrist. See The pop-up.

Strokes, manoeuvres and pop-up aren't shown while you surf: they're in the wave list in the menu (the pop-up, on the selected wave), strokes and manoeuvres also in the rating, and everything in Garmin Connect.

The pop-up

It's the time it takes you to stand up. The watch measures it with the gyroscope and accelerometer in your wrist, 25 times per second, from the end of your last stroke until you're standing:

1. **Strokes:** while you paddle, the wrist turns hard on every stroke and is never still, because the arm comes back through the air.
2. **Still hands:** you put your hands on the board and push. The wrist moves with the board and barely rotates. **The pop-up starts here.**
3. **Push and landing:** the hands leave the board, the arms go up (the wrist rotates fast) and the accelerometer marks the push.
4. **Standing:** the wrist settles. **It ends here.**



The chart is a take-off built from the timings of a study of recreational surfers (below). Top, the wrist rotation; bottom, the acceleration. The orange band is what the watch measures.

You see it in the wave list (START → **Waves**): the wave selected with UP and DOWN shows its pop-up. It also goes in each wave's lap in Garmin Connect. If the wrist doesn't show that sequence, it says "—" (0 in Connect). That happens when your hands never paused, when you weren't paddling or with the gyroscope off.



It's a first version. The rule was built before there were real take-offs to tune it on, so it can be off. In Calibrate mode each session saves the raw accelerometer and gyroscope, and these sessions will be used to tune the thresholds (how it works).

For reference, what the studies say (all on land; there are no published numbers in the water, nor for beginners):

Who	From → to	Time
Competitive surfers	the chest lifts off → the front foot lands	0.56 s (men), 0.68 s (women)
Experienced recreational surfers	hands touch the board → become stable (what the watch measures)	1.2 s
Intermediates around 25 years old	same	1.1 s
Intermediates around 50 years old	same	2.0 s

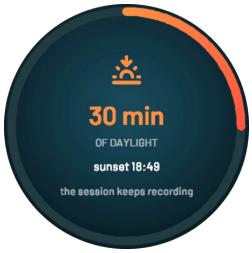
Current and drift

When you're sitting there waiting, the watch looks at how much you move without paddling. After about 2 minutes of staying still (and half a minute after your last wave), it calculates the **current**: how fast it carries you and in which direction. It shows up on Take-off and stays until it measures again. If you paddle or catch a wave, it starts measuring again.

While you wait, it also measures the **swell period** from the bobbing of the board. It's experimental: it's good for comparing with the forecast.

If while you wait the current takes you **150 metres** away from your take-off zone, it warns you with a long vibration (see Alerts).

Alerts



Each alert vibrates long and shows a banner that says "the session keeps recording". It closes on its own after 8 seconds, or sooner with BACK or START. They're turned on and off in **Settings → Alerts**.

Alert	When	Default
Sunset	30 minutes before sunset	on
Tide	When high or low tide arrives (at the time it falls)	on
Drift	If, while waiting, you drift 150 m from the take-off zone	on
Every 30 min	Every half hour of session, with the waves you have so far	off

The sunset and the tide come from the forecast, which the watch downloads when you open the app with your phone nearby.

Marking waves: Calibrate and Automatic mode

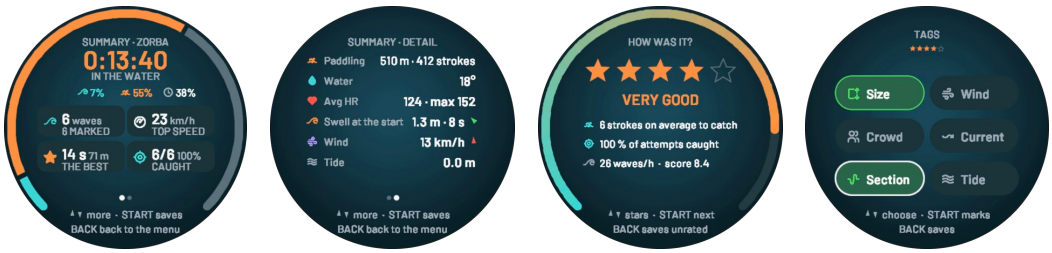
Calibrate is the default. When each real wave ends, press **BACK twice**. The watch compares your marks with what it counted and shows you good / missed / extra. It also saves a second-by-second log, with the raw accelerometer and gyroscope (25 readings per second), to improve detection and to learn to measure the pop-up with your waves. That log makes the activity bigger (about 0.6 MB more per hour), so it takes a little longer to transfer to Garmin Connect.

When the counts add up for you, switch to **Automatic** (Settings → Mode, or in the START menu): no marks, no log and a cleaner screen. If you still want to mark in Automatic, turn on "Mark with BACK"; those marks stay only in Garmin Connect.

A mark counts for a wave if you make it from a little before you stand up until 60 seconds after it ends, as long as you haven't caught another one. Easiest: mark as soon as the wave ends, or when you paddle back out.

Ending the session

With START → Save → START you get to the summary, the rating and the tags.



Summary (two pages, UP and DOWN switch between them): - The time **in the water** and how it was split: riding (turquoise), paddling (orange) and waiting (grey). - **Waves** (in Calibrate, also how many you marked; in Automatic, how many frontside and backside according to your stance; the lefts and rights are on the Waves page), **top speed**, **the best** (the one with the star on the Waves page: seconds and metres) and **caught** (waves out of attempts). - On the second page: paddling (kilometres and strokes), water, average and max heart rate, and what the swell, wind and tide were like at the start. - START saves and goes on to Rate. BACK goes back to the menu with the session paused: Resume keeps recording. At the bottom it says: "▲▼ more · START saves / BACK back to the menu".

Rate ("How was it?"): starts at 3 stars. UP adds one, DOWN takes one away (from BAD to EPIC). The bezel shows an automatic score from 0 to 10 and at the bottom go two figures from your session, for example "6 strokes on average to catch" or "100 % of attempts caught". START goes on to the tags. BACK saves without stars. At the bottom it says: "▲▼ stars · START next / BACK saves unrated".

Tags: Size, Wind, Crowd, Current, Section and Tide. They help you remember what was special about that session. UP and DOWN move between the tags (the one with the white border), START turns one on or off (when on it turns **green**) and BACK saves. At the bottom it says: "▲▼ choose · START marks / BACK saves".

When saving, "Saved · IN GARMIN CONNECT" appears, the watch vibrates twice and goes back to Home, ready for another session. If you turn off "Rate when saving", START on the summary saves straight away.

If the watch closes the app while you're recording, the session is saved anyway, without stars.

Stars

Every time you give stars to a session, the watch saves what the conditions were like at the start: waves, period, where the swell was coming from, wind, tide and time. Then, for any hour of the forecast, it looks for your sessions **at that same spot** with similar conditions and shows you the average of the stars you gave them. The most similar ones weigh more.

- With few similar sessions (fewer than 3), it blends your stars with an estimate from the forecast (size, period, wind and beach orientation). With none, you see only the estimate.
- "1 session", "4 sessions" next to the stars says how many similar sessions it's based on.
- Stars appear on **Home** (for right now), on the **Forecast** page (over the best hours of the day) and in the **Best window** complication (see below).
- In Settings → Stars you choose "History + estimate" (default), "History only" or "No". With "No" they don't appear anywhere; with "History only", only when you've rated similar sessions at that spot.

The more sessions you rate, the better it knows you.

History and records



Settings → History shows: - The **records of the spot** you're at: most waves in a session, the longest wave and your best rating. - **Your best conditions** at that spot: what the waves, wind and tide were like in the session you gave the most stars to. - **Your sessions**, newest to oldest (from all spots): date, spot, waves and stars. UP and DOWN choose one and **START** opens it.

A session shows the day and time, the spot, your stars, the waves, the longest one, the board, the water, what the sea was like when you went in (the swell and whether it came in straight, the wind and whether it was offshore, in Home's colours, and the tide and whether it was rising or falling) and the tags you gave it. UP and DOWN go to the previous or next session; BACK returns to the list.

Its waves: for the last 10 sessions, **START** shows each wave as Waves does during the session (time, seconds, top speed, metres, right or left, strokes, manoeuvres, the pop-up and frontside or backside; the best in orange with its star). On a wave, **START** shows it on the **map**: where each wave began and ended, from the take-off zone (the orange ring) and where you went in (the pin), with the beach at the bottom, rights in teal and lefts in orange; UP and DOWN move between waves. Older sessions show the summary, and their waves stay in Garmin Connect. Waves are kept from this version on: sessions recorded before don't have them.

To see another spot's records, change the spot first (Settings → Spot). The watch keeps up to 60 sessions per spot and 200 in total; when it hits the limit the oldest ones are deleted. If the watch's memory fills up, the first thing to go is the waves of the oldest session that has them.

Boards

The board you're carrying appears above START and is saved in each session (also in Garmin Connect, in the **Board** field).

- **Choosing it:** Settings → Board. Each one shows its length, litres and how many sessions it has. It stays selected for the next sessions. The board is fixed when you press START: you can't change it in the water.
- **Adding your own:** on the phone, Connect IQ app → Surf Dawn Session → Settings → Boards (up to 12, with model, length and litres), or in the iPhone app (Profile → Boards), which sends them to the watch and replaces the Connect IQ ones. The app doesn't come with boards: until you add them, sessions are recorded without a board. Until you pick one, the first on your list is used.
- **None:** records the session without a board.
- **Remove a board:** takes it off the watch's list (asks for confirmation). To get it back, add it again from the phone.

Settings

Hold **UP** (MENU) on Home or while recording, or choose **Settings** in the DOWN menu. START changes the value or opens the option, BACK closes.



Setting	Options (defaults in bold)	What it's for
Board	your boards, None, Remove a board	See Boards
Stance	**Goofy**, Regular	Which foot you surf with forward: with that each wave comes out as frontside or backside, and the Pre-surf squat and pop-up face your way
Watch on	**left**, right	Which wrist you wear the watch on. It's saved with each wave in Garmin Connect to tune the pop-up
Spot	the spot picker	Choose the spot by hand
Detection	**Wall**, Whitewater, Performance, Custom	**Whitewater** for small, slow waves or whitewater; **Wall**, the everyday one; **Performance** for big, fast waves (asks for more speed and distance). With the iPhone app your level picks it (Profile → Your surfing)
Custom	Take-off (**7** km/h), Minimum peak (**10** km/h), Minimum distance (**10** m), Minimum duration (**3** s), Between waves (**15** s), Towards the shore (**yes**)	Your own thresholds. Changing one switches detection to Custom. "Towards the shore: no" also counts waves that don't head toward the beach
Mode	**Calibrate**, Automatic	See Marking waves
Mark with BACK	yes, **no**	Mark waves in Automatic too
Vibrate on detection	**yes**, no	One vibration for each wave counted
Water temperature	**Sensor**, Forecast, Both	Which water to show and save: the one the watch measures (from 8 minutes in), the forecast's, or the forecast until the sensor is ready. On watches without a thermometer, Sensor shows the forecast's
GPS	**Multi-band**, Max accuracy, SatIQ, GPS only	Multi-band is the most accurate; SatIQ uses less battery. Max accuracy is dynamic SatIQ in its most accurate mode (the fēnix 9 watches, the Enduro 4 and the MARQ Gen 3): it uses more battery than SatIQ. Only the ones your watch takes show up. On watches without multi-band, Multi-band uses all systems on one band
Gyroscope	**yes**, no	Counts manoeuvres with wrist turns; off, it uses less battery. On watches without a gyroscope nothing changes
1 Hz log	yes, **no**	Save the second-by-second log (with the raw accelerometer and gyroscope) in Automatic too
Lap per wave	**yes**, no	One lap per wave in Garmin Connect. Off, the activity is a single lap, with no wave data
Alerts	Sunset, Tide, Drift, Every 30 min	See Alerts
History		See History and records
Rate when saving	**yes**, no	Ask for stars and tags when saving
Stars	**History + estimate**, History only, No	See Stars

Setting	Options (defaults in bold)	What it's for
Waves	**Total**, Swell	Total = the whole sea (like the "Wave" row on Windguru); Swell = just the ground swell
Height	**Metres**, Feet	
Wind	**km/h**, Knots	Also the speed of the waves
Touch in session	yes, **no**	Use the touchscreen with the session open
Background	**Sea**, Night, Graphite, Forest	The background colour, as on the face
Language	**Match the watch**, Español, English, Português	Session's screens; the names of the data in Garmin Connect follow the watch's (Languages)
Version	(read only)	The installed version; with "dev" at the end, loaded by cable

While recording, Board, Stance, Watch on, Spot, Detection, Custom, GPS, Gyroscope, 1 Hz log, Lap per wave, History and Language don't appear: you choose them before starting. These settings belong to Session only: Garmin doesn't let one app read another's, so units, background and language are chosen in each app.

What ends up in Garmin Connect

The session shows up as **Surfing**, with your route and your heart rate, and also:

- **One lap per wave** (if "Lap per wave" is on), with how long the wave lasted, the metres, the side, whether you marked it, the max and average speed, the strokes to catch it, the manoeuvres, the pop-up (0 when it couldn't be measured) and whether it was frontside (1) or backside (-1). Off, you get a single lap with that data empty; the waves are still counted in the session data.
- **Session data:** waves, attempts, the longest, minutes riding and paddling, strokes, distance paddled, water, what the watch measured (swell period and current), the conditions at the start, spot, board, stars, tags and score.
- **In Calibrate mode**, two more charts: what you were doing (waiting, paddling, riding, duck dive) and the paddling.

The routines are separate activities: Pre-surf and Post-surf as Flexibility training and the CO2 and O2 tables and the apnea test as Breathwork, with a lap per exercise.

Garmin Connect shows this data under its own names when the app is installed from the Connect IQ store. If you installed it by cable, it's still inside the activity file.

With the iPhone app

The Surf Dawn iPhone app receives your sessions. You connect it once, from the app: Profile → Watches → Connect a Garmin, which opens Garmin Connect to choose the watch.

- **Every session you save** reaches the phone with its waves, its map, the time surfing, paddling and waiting, the distance paddled and the strokes. If the phone isn't nearby, the session waits on the watch (up to 60) and goes the next time you open Session with the phone nearby.
- **Your waves on the satellite:** with the take-off zone marked, each wave shows on the spot's satellite photo, with the sea at the top; you can replay the session wave by wave and open each one with its figures. Under them, **where you paddled**: the watch counts the seconds paddling in 10 m squares and the app paints them as a heat map, from yellow (a little) to red (where you paddled the most); the Paddling button turns it off and on. And the **photos of that day** in your camera roll, each with the wave its time falls in.
- **Profile:** your numbers (sessions per month, waves per hour, the time in the water), your records, your spots and which sea you surf best in, by your stars.
- **The history you already had** is asked for by the app when you connect the watch (and with Profile → Watches → Ask for the history): up to 60 sessions of the history arrive, and the waves of the last 10.
- **In iCloud:** with Sync with iCloud (Profile → Your data) your sessions, with their waves and where you paddled, show up on your other iPhones with the same Apple ID, and come back if you change iPhone or delete the app.

- **Stars and tags** can be changed on the phone. With your sessions, the app shows at each spot the stars you gave to similar conditions.
- **Your boards** are entered in the app (Profile → Boards) and go to the watch: they replace the ones in the Connect IQ app.
- **Your surfing** (Profile → Your surfing): your stance (goofy or regular) and the watch's wrist go to Session's Settings, the same as changing them on the watch. And your **level** picks the Detection: beginner, Whitewater; intermediate, Wall; advanced, Performance. The app suggests one from your waves (the top speed half of your last waves go over). It changes the Detection only when you change the level: if you then pick another on the watch, that one stays.
- **A new watch:** when you connect it, the app gives it your history (the sessions the phone has, with your stars), your boards and Your surfing, and your stars come back in the watch's forecast. It can also be done by hand: Profile → Watches → Send yours. What the watch already had stays as it was.

Without the iPhone app, Session works as always.

Session on other watch faces

Session publishes two complications that any compatible face can show: - **Surf Dawn Session**: your last session ("8 waves"). From the Surf Dawn face you open it by pressing and holding the water temperature. - **Surf Dawn Best window**: the two hours of the day with the most stars for you ("14-16 h · 4/5"). When you open Session from there, it starts on the day's conditions.

Both are calculated every time you save a session: the best window is the one for the day you saved the last one.

How waves are detected, in detail, and how it was tested: Session design.

Install, Garmin watches and FAQ

Install

- **From the Connect IQ Store:** the **Surf Dawn** face and **Surf Dawn Forecast** are free: search for them in the Connect IQ app on your phone, install them and they update themselves. You change their phone settings from there.
- **Session** isn't in the store yet: for now it's a private beta. The face and Forecast work without it.
- **The Apple Watch and the iPhone:** a single app, Surf Dawn, for iPhone with iOS 17 or later, which brings the Apple Watch one with it (watchOS 10 or later). For now it's a beta with TestFlight (Install).

Supported watches

All three apps run on Garmin **round watches with 5 buttons** and Connect IQ 4.2 or later: 50 models.

Display	Watches
AMOLED	fēnix 9 Pro (43, 47 and 51 mm), fēnix 9 (43, 47 and 51 mm), fēnix 8 (43, 47 and 51 mm), fēnix 8 Pro (47 and 51 mm, also MicroLED), tactix 8, quatix 8 and 8 Pro, fēnix E, epix Pro (Gen 2) in 42, 47 and 51 mm, epix (Gen 2), quatix 7 Pro and Sapphire, tactix 7 AMOLED, MARQ (Gen 2) and MARQ Aviator, MARQ (Gen 3), D2 Mach 1, Mach 1 Pro, Mach 2 and Mach 2 Pro, Forerunner 965, 970, 570 (42 and 47 mm), 265, 170, 165 and 70 (and their Music versions), Descent Mk3 and Mk3i 43 mm, Descent Mk3i 51 mm, Descent G2, Instinct 3 AMOLED (45 and 50 mm) and Instinct Crossover AMOLED
MIP (transflective display)	fēnix 7, 7 Pro and 7 Pro Solar, fēnix 7X, 7X Pro and 7X Pro Solar, tactix 7, quatix 7 and 7X Solar, Enduro 2, 3 and 4, fēnix 8 Solar (47 and 51 mm), tactix 8 Solar, fēnix 9 Pro Solar (47 and 51 mm), Forerunner 955 (and Solar), 255 and 255 Music

Differences you will notice:

- **MIP:** flat colours and the face has no second hand. The display never turns off, so at rest you still see the full face.
- **Instinct Crossover AMOLED:** it has real hands, so the face doesn't draw its own and has no digital-time option.
- **No touchscreen** (Forerunner 255 and 255 Music, Instinct 3 AMOLED, Instinct Crossover AMOLED): the face gestures don't exist (open Forecast and Session from the app list) and Forecast shows a single day.

Watches with 2 or 3 buttons (Venu, vívoactive, Approach, D2 Air), monochrome-display Instincts, smaller displays (fēnix 7S, Forerunner 255s and 265s) and watches older than Connect IQ 4.2 (fēnix 6, first-generation MARQ, Forerunner 945) are not supported. Every model is listed on each app's page in the Connect IQ store.

What each watch measures

All of them have GPS, an accelerometer and a heart-rate sensor: that is enough to count waves, paddling and distance on any of them. The other sensors vary by model (Garmin spec sheets, October 2026).

- **Price** compares Garmin's list price when the model came out, not what it costs in any particular country: **$** up to US$350, **$$** up to US$650, **$$$** up to US$1,000, **$$$$** up to US$1,500 and **$$$$$** above that. The table runs from cheapest to most expensive; with sales or in another country the number changes, but it is good for comparing.
- **Session** is a star rating: how many of the five sensors Session makes use of the watch has (gyroscope, barometer, thermometer, compass and multi-band GPS). The touchscreen doesn't count, because in the water Session is operated with the buttons.

Watch	Price	Session	Gyroscope	Barometer	Thermometer	Compass	Multi-band GPS	Touch
Forerunner 255 and 255 Music	$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	**no**
Forerunner 170 and 170 Music	$	★★★★☆	yes	yes	yes	yes	**no**	yes
Forerunner 165 and 165 Music	$	★★★☆☆	**no**	yes	yes	yes	**no**	yes
Forerunner 70	$	☆☆☆☆☆	**no**	**no**	**no**	**no**	**no**	yes
Forerunner 265	$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
Forerunner 955 and 955 Solar	$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
Forerunner 570 (42 and 47 mm)	$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
Forerunner 965	$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
Instinct 3 AMOLED (45 and 50 mm)	$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	**no**
Instinct Crossover AMOLED	$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	**no**
Descent G2	$$	★★★★☆	yes	yes	yes	yes	**no**	yes
Forerunner 970	$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
fēnix 7 Pro and 7 Pro Solar	$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
fēnix 7X Pro and 7X Pro Solar	$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
fēnix 7 Sapphire Solar	$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
fēnix 7X Sapphire Solar	$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
epix Pro (Gen 2) 42, 47 and 51 mm	$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
epix (Gen 2) Sapphire	$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
quatix 7 Sapphire	$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
quatix 7X Solar	$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
Enduro 3	$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
Enduro 4	$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
fēnix 9 (43, 47 and 51 mm)	$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
fēnix 8 (43, 47 and 51 mm)	$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
fēnix 8 Solar (47 and 51 mm)	$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
fēnix 7 and 7 Solar (without Sapphire), quatix 7	$$$	★★★★☆	yes	yes	yes	yes	**no**	yes
fēnix E	$$$	★★★★☆	yes	yes	yes	yes	**no**	yes
fēnix 7X Solar (without Sapphire)	$$$	★★★★☆	yes	yes	yes	yes	**no**	yes
epix (Gen 2) without Sapphire	$$$	★★★★☆	yes	yes	yes	yes	**no**	yes
fēnix 9 Pro (43, 47 and 51 mm)	$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
fēnix 9 Pro Solar (47 and 51 mm)	$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
Descent Mk3 and Mk3i 43 mm	$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
Enduro 2	$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
tactix 7 and tactix 7 AMOLED	$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
quatix 7 Pro	$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes

Watch	Price	Session	Gyroscope	Barometer	Thermometer	Compass	Multi-band GPS	Touch
quatix 8	$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
fēnix 8 Pro (47 and 51 mm)	$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
tactix 8 and tactix 8 Solar	$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
D2 Mach 1 and Mach 1 Pro	$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
quatix 8 Pro	$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
D2 Mach 2	$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
D2 Mach 2 Pro	$$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
Descent Mk3i 51 mm	$$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
MARQ (Gen 2): Athlete, Adventurer, Captain, Golfer, Carbon, Commander Carbon	$$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
fēnix 8 Pro MicroLED	$$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
MARQ (Gen 2) Aviator	$$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes
MARQ (Gen 3): Athlete, Adventurer, Aviator, Commander, Golfer, Diver	$$$$$	★★★★★	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes	yes

Zero stars doesn't mean it doesn't work: the Forerunner 70 counts waves, paddling and distance like any other. The face and Forecast work the same on all of them, because they use the GPS and the phone's data, not these sensors.

What changes in Session when the watch lacks a sensor:

If it doesn't have	What you lose	What Session does instead
Gyroscope	Manoeuvres from wrist rotations and the pop-up time	It counts manoeuvres from GPS changes of direction. The pop-up reads "—" and the Gyroscope setting changes nothing
Barometer	Knowing when you duck under a wave: no "duck dive" appears and it can't use it to discard false waves	It counts waves just the same, with the GPS and the accelerometer
Thermometer	The water temperature measured at your wrist	Water temperature → Sensor shows the forecast's value 30 seconds after the start
Compass	The Take-off ring following where the watch points when you are still	While you move, the ring turns with your heading (GPS). Standing still, after 10 seconds it settles with north up and the top just says "N"
Multi-band GPS	Extra accuracy near cliffs, piers or buildings	GPS → Multi-band uses all systems on a single band
Touchscreen	The face's gestures and seeing more than one day in Forecast	Everything is operated with the buttons; Forecast and Session open from the app list

Languages

The apps are in **Spanish** if the watch is set to Spanish, in **Portuguese** if it is set to Portuguese, and in **English** if it is set to any other language. The same goes for the names of Session's data in Garmin Connect.

Forecast and Session can use another one: **Settings → Language**, Match the watch (out of the box), Español, English or Português. The app changes at once and, in Forecast, so do the morning alert, the glance and the complications. Each app has its own (Garmin doesn't let one app read another's settings). What stays in the watch's language: the apps' names and their complications', their settings in the Connect IQ app on the phone, the names of Session's data in Garmin Connect, and the face, Rings and the data fields.

On the Apple Watch and the iPhone it works the same way: Settings → **Language**, Match the watch (or Match the iPhone), Español, English or Português, each device its own (iPhone settings).

inReach messages

Watches with inReach (such as the fēnix 9 Pro) send and receive messages by satellite. No Connect IQ app can read or send them, but the watch's own access works on any screen, even while recording a session (the session keeps recording):

1. Hold **LIGHT**: the controls menu opens.
2. Choose **Messenger** to read and reply, or **Check-in** to send your "I'm OK" with your location. **SOS** is there too.

To have Messenger first: with the controls menu open, hold **MENU** → Reorder Controls, choose Messenger and move it up. If it doesn't appear, add it with Add Controls. From the face, the inReach glance is in the glance list (DOWN).

With the phone far away or out of signal, the watch uses the satellite. New messages also arrive as a notification during the session, if you have notifications during activities turned on.

If your watch offers Messenger to watch faces, touching and holding the top row of the Surf Dawn face (sunrise and sunset) opens it.

Frequently asked questions

The numbers are grey and it says "4 H AGO". No new data has arrived for more than 3 hours. The phone has no connection or Garmin Connect is closed. If there is also a crossed-out phone, the watch isn't connected to the phone.

It says "LOADING" or "—". It is a new spot and its data hasn't arrived yet. Nearby spots load instantly; a distant one takes a few minutes, because Garmin only allows an update once every 5 minutes.

Total or Swell? Total is the whole sea: the groundswell plus the waves the wind builds. It is what Windguru shows in the "Wave" row and it is the default. Swell is the groundswell only.

Does the tide include the wind? No. It is the astronomical tide from the official table of the nearest port. In a sudestada (a strong southeasterly storm surge) the water rises higher than it says.

The face, Forecast and Session show different spots. The spot you choose in Forecast also carries over to the face. But Session picks its own with the GPS when it starts, and the fixed spot from Customize doesn't carry over to Forecast. Garmin doesn't let one app read what another one saved.

Why do I have to choose units and background in each app? For the same reason: each app stores its own settings. The defaults are the same in all three.

The watch missed a wave, or counted an extra one. Use Calibrate mode and mark your waves with BACK twice: you will see how many it got right. If the waves at your spot are small and slow, try the Whitewater detection; if they are big and fast, Performance (Session settings).

Does it measure the pop-up? Yes, as an estimate: it lasts about a second and the watch samples your wrist 25 times a second, so that is enough. You see it in the wave list (the selected wave) and in each wave's lap in Garmin Connect. It is a first version, built before there were real take-offs to test with, and it can be off: in Calibrate mode each session saves the raw accelerometer and gyroscope data so it can be tuned with your waves (how it is measured).

The water says "—" at the start of the session. The watch's sensor needs 8 minutes to stop feeling the heat of your wrist. If you want a number from the start, choose Water temperature → Both. Watches without a thermometer show the forecast's value after 30 seconds (which ones).

What happens if the app closes while I'm recording? The session is saved anyway, with no stars.

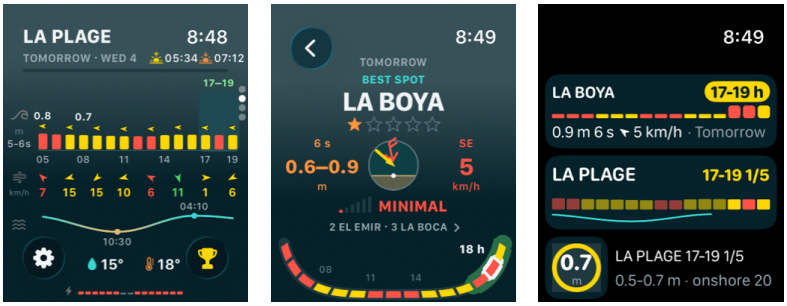
Does it show up in Garmin Connect? Yes: as Surfing, with one lap per wave. Session's own data (waves, strokes, board, stars) appears under its name if the app is installed from the store; otherwise it stays inside the activity file.

How do I use less battery? In Session, GPS SatIQ instead of Multi-band or Max accuracy and the gyroscope off (it won't count manoeuvres from your wrist). On the face, the Graphite background.

Is Garmin's own Surf activity still useful? Yes, and it is good for comparing. If you use it, set GPS to "All Systems + Multi-Band" and recording to "Every Second".

Surf Dawn on the Apple Watch

On the Apple Watch, Surf Dawn is a single app with **Forecast** and **Session**, plus **the morning alert**, **the complications** and **the Smart Stack**. It uses the same spots, the same data and the same best-hours calculation as on Garmin, with the same wording. It comes inside the iPhone app, and on the watch it works on its own, without the iPhone nearby.



Getting started

1. **Install Surf Dawn on the iPhone** (see Install). The watch app installs with it.
2. **Open it on the watch** and let it use your location: with that it picks the nearest spot and downloads the spots of your zone. Also let it send you notifications, for the morning alert.
3. **Choose your units and your background** in Settings (the gear button, bottom left). They come set to metres, km/h and the Sea background.
4. **Tell it how you surf**, on the iPhone: Profile → Your surfing → your **level**. With that, Session picks how it detects your waves (Your surfing).
5. **Check the forecast:** the app opens on your spot's day, with the three best hours marked. The trophy, bottom right, opens Today: the best spot among the ones near you.
6. **Before you go in the water,** scroll down with the Digital Crown to **Session** and tap **Start**. In the water, the first page shows **GPS** in green once it has a signal.
7. **When you come out:** on the last page, **End**; give it stars and **Save**. It's kept on the iPhone and in Health.

Install

- **A single app:** Surf Dawn is an iPhone app that brings the Apple Watch one with it. If Automatic App Install is on in the iPhone's Watch app, the watch installs it by itself; if not, in the Watch app → Available Apps → Surf Dawn → **Install**.
- **It needs** watchOS 10 or later on the watch and iOS 17 or later on the iPhone.
- **It's free**, with no ads and no account. If you like, you can leave a tip from the iPhone (Support Surf Dawn).
- **It isn't in the App Store yet:** for now it's a beta installed with TestFlight, by invitation.
- **Permissions** are asked for when they're needed: location and notifications when you open it, and Health and Motion & Fitness the first time you start a session (Health to save it as a Surfing workout, with the map and heart rate; Motion & Fitness for the barometer, which tells when you're under water).

Forecast

Garmin's forecast page in the Apple Watch's shape: your spot's day hour by hour, from 5 to 19 h, on a single screen. It reads the same as on Garmin (How to read it):

- **At the top,** the spot and the time; below, the day ("TOMORROW · WED 4") and the sunrise and sunset times.
- **The waves** (the wave row): one bar per hour, taller the bigger they are, in that hour's colour at your beach: green if the swell comes in head-on and the wind is offshore, yellow if one of them is fair, red if one doesn't work. Above the bars, the height wherever it changes and the little arrows showing where the waves are heading; the smaller, hollow one is the other swell, when it matters. On the left, the unit and the period.
- **The best-hours band:** a box behind the three best hours with daylight, with their hours above it ("17–19"). It's the same calculation as on Garmin (The best hours); if the day has nothing worthwhile, it doesn't appear.

- **The wind** (the wind row), every two hours: an arrow showing where it blows toward and the speed, in green (offshore), yellow (cross-shore) or red (onshore).
- **The tide** (the tide row): the day's curve, with the times of high and low tide.
- **At the bottom,** between the two buttons, the water and the air; along the bottom edge, the sea's energy hour by hour.
- Hours that have already passed look dimmer, and a line marks the current hour.

Gesture	What it does
Turn the Digital Crown or swipe up	Tomorrow and the day after; then, Session
Tap the spot (top)	The spot picker
Touch and hold the page	Request the data again
Gear (bottom left)	Settings
Trophy (bottom right)	Today

The spot picker is Garmin's (Choosing the spot): **Automatic** at the top (the nearest), your zone's spots from nearest to farthest with their distance, **Saved zones** (and **Remove this zone**), **The whole world** to download another region, and **Break type** to correct a spot's type (**As shipped** puts it back). The spot you pick also goes to the complications.

With no connection it shows the latest it downloaded for that spot, with since when in orange, as on Garmin (No connection). If it has nothing that reaches today, it says **NO CONNECTION · TAP TO RETRY**.

Today

It opens with the **trophy** (bottom right), from Settings → **Best spot today**, when you open the morning alert or when you tap the Smart Stack. It's Garmin's Today page, with the bezel turned into an arc across the bottom half of the screen.

- **Which spot:** from the alert, the Smart Stack or Settings, the day's best ("BEST SPOT"); from the trophy, the one you were looking at, with its place among the nearby spots. After 19 h, tomorrow.
- **The arc is the day,** from 05 h on the left to 20 h on the right, with midday at the bottom: one segment per hour in the colour of the swell and the wind at that beach, and the best window marked.
- **The hour you're looking at:** it opens on the current one (**NOW**). The Digital Crown moves from hour to hour, and a tap on the arc jumps to that hour.
- **Inside, for that hour:** the spot and its stars; the **spot's rose** (your beach seen from above, with the sea at the top: the swell as a thick arrow and the wind as a thin one, coming in from where they come from, in their colour); on the left the waves, from the average wave to the sets, with the period above; on the right the wind, with where it blows from; and at the bottom the sea's energy.
- **A weak day** says **WEAK DAY** in red.
- **The other spots,** at the bottom ("2 LA BOCA · 3 LA MARTINEZ"): a tap opens **Spots nearby**, from best to worst, each with its window and its stars.
- **A tap in the middle** opens that spot's forecast, without changing the one you picked.

The morning alert

Every day, at the time you choose, the watch tells you **the best spot to surf today** among the ones near you: "Today: EL EMIR", the waves and the period in the day's best window ("1.4 m 6 s · 07-09 h") and the next two ("Next: …"), or the ones that are about as good ("As good: LA PLAGE, ZORBA"). It compares the same spots with the same calculation as on Garmin: the 12 nearest in your zone, within 25 km (how it picks).

- **The time:** Settings → **Alert time**, from 06:00 to 09:00 every 15 minutes (06:00 out of the box). **Morning alert** turns it on or off; it comes on.
- **It arrives on time even without a connection:** at night, from 21:00, the app downloads tomorrow's ranking and leaves the alert scheduled with it ("last night"). Ten minutes before the time it tries to download it with the models' latest run and, if it arrives, replaces it. If the new one arrives after last night's has already alerted, it alerts again only if the best spot, the window or the day's colour changed. Without a connection it retries every 15 minutes for four hours.
- **A weak day doesn't alert.**
- **It stays in Notification Center** on the watch. **Open** opens Today with the best spot.

- **If it didn't come,** Settings → **Last try** says when it last tried and how it went: "notified", "weak day", "no connection", "no spots" (open and close the app once, so it saves your zone's spots) or another error code.
- **There's no "At wake time":** watchOS doesn't give apps the sleep schedule, so the alert goes at a fixed time. If the watch is in Sleep Focus or Do Not Disturb at that time, it may not vibrate; it still stays in Notification Center and in the Smart Stack.

Complications and Smart Stack

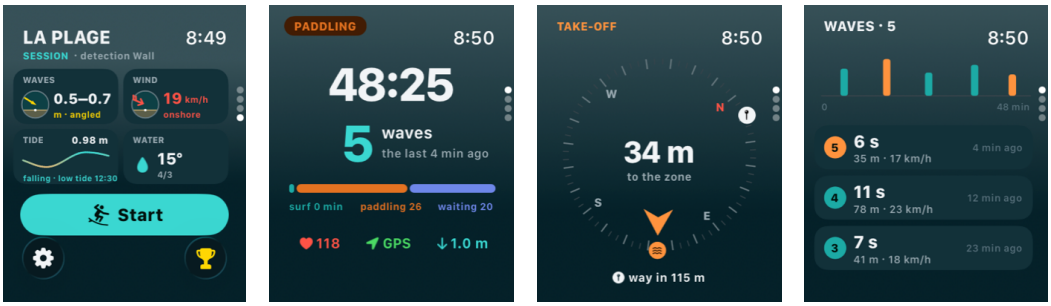
Apple doesn't let other apps make watch faces, so the Surf Dawn face isn't on the Apple Watch. Instead, Surf Dawn puts your spot on the Apple watch faces that take complications (Modular Ultra, Infograph, Wayfinder, Modular and others):

Complication	What it shows
Rectangular	The spot and its best hours, over each hour's waves in their colour and the tide
Circular	The height now, in a ring the colour of the day
Corner	The height and the next high or low tide
Inline	The spot and its best hours

- **To add them:** touch and hold the watch face → **Edit** → Complications, tap a slot and choose **Surf Dawn**.
- **The Smart Stack** (turn the Digital Crown from the watch face) has **Best spot today**, which on Garmin is Forecast's glance: the day's best spot with its window in a pill the colour of the day, the bar of hours in green, yellow and red, the waves and the wind. From the alert time until the window ends, watchOS moves it to the top by itself. If it doesn't appear, touch and hold the Smart Stack and add it with **+**. Tapping it opens Today.
- **They update on their own:** the watch requests the spot's day again when its data gets old. Tapping a complication opens the app.

Session

Session on the Apple Watch is Garmin's Session, inside the same app: it records the session as a **Surfing** workout in Health, with its map and heart rate, and counts the waves with the same detector as Session on Garmin, second by second, with the GPS, the accelerometer and the barometer. Sessions go to the iPhone, where you see the waves on the satellite (Sessions).



Before you go in: Home

Scrolling down with the Digital Crown past the forecast days. It's Garmin's Home screen:

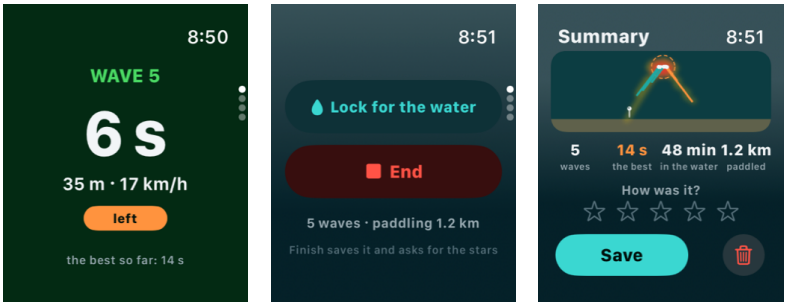
- **At the top,** the spot and the **Detection** your level picked on the iPhone (Profile → Your surfing): beginner, Whitewater; intermediate, Wall; advanced, Performance. With no level, Wall.
- **Four cards:** the **waves** over the spot's rose, with how they hit the beach (head-on, angled, shadowed); the **wind**, with its class (offshore, cross-shore, onshore); the **tide**, with the day's curve and the next high or low; and the **water**, with the recommended wetsuit (The recommended wetsuit).
- **Start** starts the session.

In the water: four pages

The Digital Crown moves from one to the next. They all sit on your background (Settings → Background).

1. **Session:** what you're doing, in its colour (**PADDLING**, **WAITING**, **ON A WAVE**, **UNDER WATER**); the session time, big; the waves and how long since the last one; the time split between surfing, paddling and waiting; and at the bottom the heart rate, the GPS and the tide.
2. **Take-off:** a compass that turns with the watch (north in red), with the arrow and the distance to the take-off zone and to the entry. The zone is the middle of where your waves started this session; before the first one, the one from your earlier sessions at that spot. It's Garmin's Take-off page.
3. **Waves:** the session over time, one bar per wave (taller the longer it lasted, teal the rights and orange the lefts), and the last three, with the best one marked with its star.
4. **End: Lock for the water** (the watch's Water Lock: the screen ignores drops; to unlock it, turn the Digital Crown) and **End**.

Each wave counted: the watch taps your wrist and shows the wave for 4 seconds, or until you tap it: its number, the seconds, the metres, the top speed, whether it went right or left, and the best so far.



When you come out: the summary

End closes the session (there's no pause: it's final) and leaves it in Health as a Surfing workout, with the map and heart rate. Then comes the summary: your waves seen from above (the sea at the top, the sand at the bottom) with **where you paddled** as a warm glow, the number of waves, the best one, the time in the water and how far you paddled; below, **How was it?** with your stars. **Save** sends it to the iPhone, with your stars; the bin doesn't send it, but the workout stays in Health (you delete it in the Health app).

- **Your history lives on the iPhone:** the watch keeps the last 60 sessions in case the iPhone isn't nearby, and hands them over when it is again.
- **Stars and tags** are changed later on the iPhone, in the session.
- **It's a first version:** with recorded sessions the detector gives the same waves as on Garmin, but on the Apple Watch it's still being tested in the water.

Differences from Garmin

What the Apple Watch does differently, and why:

	Garmin	Apple Watch
The watch face	The Surf Dawn face	There isn't one: Apple doesn't allow other apps' watch faces. The complications put the spot on Apple's watch faces
Apps	The face, Forecast and Session, each with its own settings	A single app, with a single set of settings
The morning alert	At the time you choose or **At wake time**	At the time you choose, from 06:00 to 09:00. There's no **At wake time**: watchOS doesn't give apps the sleep schedule
Where the alert stays	On the glance (Garmin doesn't keep app notifications)	In Notification Center and in the Smart Stack
Complications	Best hours, Waves now and Wind now, on Face It and on Connect IQ watch faces	Rectangular, circular, corner and inline, on Apple's watch faces. There's no wind one
Session in the water	Session, Take-off, Forecast and Waves, with the buttons	Session, Take-off, Waves and End, with the Digital Crown

	Garmin	Apple Watch
Where the session ends up	Garmin Connect (and the iPhone, if you connect it)	Health and the iPhone
Routines and apnea	In Session, on the watch	On the iPhone (Train)

What Session on the Apple Watch doesn't have from Garmin yet:

- **Pausing** the session: End is final.
- The **Custom** Detection and **Calibrate** mode; marking a wave by hand (on Garmin, BACK twice).
- Each wave's manoeuvres, strokes and pop-up (on Garmin they come from the gyroscope and the wrist).
- The alerts in the water (sunset, tide, drift, every 30 minutes), the current and drift on Take-off, and the Forecast page in the water.
- On the watch, the list of all the waves, the history and the records: they're on the iPhone, like the tags, which you add there.
- Your stars in the forecast and on Home, and Session's complications (Surf Dawn Session and Surf Dawn Best window).
- Choosing the board, and Session's settings (the Detection comes from your level on the iPhone).

Settings

The gear, bottom left on the forecast.

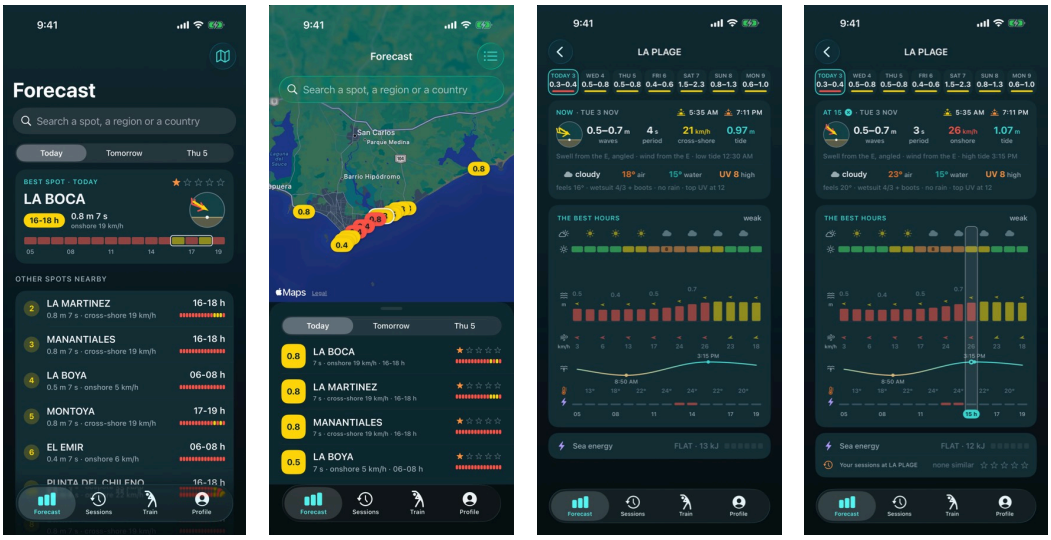
Setting	Values (factory default in bold)
Spot	opens the picker (it says **Automatic** and which one is the nearest)
Best spot today	opens Today with the best one
Morning alert	**Yes** or No
Alert time	from **06:00** to 09:00, every 15 minutes
Last try	how the alert went last time (shows up after the first try)
Waves	**Total** (the whole sea) or Swell (only the groundswell)
Height	**Metres** or Feet
Wind	**km/h** or Knots
Background	**Sea**, Night, Graphite or Forest, also in the water
Language	**Match the watch**, Español, English or Português: the app's, the alert's, the complications' and the Smart Stack's
Refresh	requests the data again; below it, it says how old the current data is
Version	the installed version

The watch's settings are its own: the iPhone's don't carry over by themselves. Two things do go from the iPhone to the watch: the **background**, with Profile → Settings → Background → **The same on the watches** (on by default), and your **level** from Your surfing, which picks Session's Detection.

Surf Dawn on the iPhone

The iPhone app is the week's forecast for your spots, your sessions with their waves on the satellite, Train and your surfer profile. It carries the Apple Watch app inside and also works with a Garmin: Session sends it every session you save. It's useful without a watch too, for the forecast and Train.

It has four tabs at the bottom: **Forecast**, **Sessions**, **Train** and **Profile**.



Install

- **From the App Store:** Surf Dawn, for iPhone with iOS 17 or later. It brings the Apple Watch app with it (Install on the Apple Watch).
- **It isn't in the App Store yet:** for now it's a beta installed with TestFlight, by invitation.
- **It's free**, with no ads and no account. The tips in Support Surf Dawn don't unlock anything.
- **Permissions** are asked for when they're needed: location when you open it (for the nearest spot), Photos only when you look for a session's photos, notifications when you ask for a reminder in Train, and Bluetooth only when you connect a Garmin. With only an Apple Watch, nothing about Garmin shows up.

Forecast

- **The best spot** of the day near you, at the top, on a card: its stars, its window ("16-18 h"), the waves and the period, the wind with its class and its unit ("cross-shore 20 km/h"), the **spot's rose** (how the swell and the wind hit the beach at the middle hour of the window) and a strip with the hours from 05 to 19 in each one's colour, with the window marked.
- **Other spots nearby,** below, in order, each with its window, its waves, its wind and its strip of hours. It's the same ranking as Today and the morning alert on the watches, with all the spots of your zone within 25 km (the watches compare the 12 nearest).
- **Today**, **Tomorrow** and the day after, at the top, change the day.
- **The map** (the button at the top right): the spots on the coast, each with its height in the day's colour, and the four best in a sheet at the bottom. **List** goes back.
- **Search** (at the top): a spot from anywhere in the world by its name, its region or its country, regardless of capitals or accents. Tapping it downloads its zone if needed, makes it your spot and opens its page. The app downloads the list of the world's spots by itself a few seconds after opening; new spots show up the next day.
- **Tap a spot** to open its page. Swipe down to request the data again.

The spot the ranking centres on is the one in Profile → Settings → **Spot**: **Automatic** (the nearest to where you are) or the one you choose.

A spot's page

Everything fits without scrolling on an iPhone Pro Max; on smaller ones you scroll.

- **The week,** at the top: the seven days, each with its waves (from the average wave to the sets, in its best window) and a stripe in the day's colour: green good, yellow fair, red weak. Tap one to see it. The week is iPhone only: the watches show three days.
- **Now** (on another day, the middle hour of its best window): the day and the sunrise and sunset; the **spot's rose** (the sea at the top and the beach at the bottom, with the swell, the other swell and the wind coming in, in the colour of how they hit the beach); the waves, from the average wave to the sets; the period; the wind in its colour with its class (offshore, cross-shore, onshore); the tide; and a sentence with the rest ("Swell from the E, angled · wind from the E · low tide 00:30"). Below, the weather: the sky, the air, the water and the day's highest UV, with the feels-like temperature, the wetsuit, the rain to come and the time of the highest UV. The UV goes in the WHO levels: low, moderate, high, very high and extreme.
- **The best hours:** the day hour by hour, like the watches' forecast page: the wave bars in their colour, the arrows of the swell and the other swell, the wind, the tide and the best-hours band. Above, each hour's sky with the UV in cells of its level; below, the air in degrees and the sea's energy hour by hour.
- **Tap an hour** on the chart to mark it: its column, its number in a turquoise pill and its dot on the tide. The card at the top becomes that hour's ("AT 15 ✕"), with its exact figures, and so do the energy and your sessions. Tap it again, or the ✕, to go back to now. With VoiceOver, swipe up or down to move from hour to hour.
- **At the bottom,** the sea's energy and **your sessions at** that spot: the stars you gave to similar conditions there ("none similar" if there are none yet).
- Swipe down to request the data again.

Sessions

They arrive on their own: those from Session on the Apple Watch when you save them, and those from Session on a Garmin once you connect it in Profile → Watches. The tab shows the month in numbers (sessions, waves, hours in the water, stars) and your sessions by month, each with the map of its waves.



A session

- **Your waves on the satellite**, over the take-off zone, with the sea at the top (the view faces where the beach faces): each wave from where you stood up to where it ended, with its number; the rights in teal and the lefts in orange; the take-off zone and the entry. **Satellite** or **Map**, at the top. If the session didn't save where its waves were (those from before 27 October 2026, or older than the Garmin's last 10), you still see the satellite, with the waves drawn from the take-off zone of another session at that spot and a line saying it's approximate.
- **Where you paddled:** the watch counts the seconds paddling in 10 m squares and the app paints them as a heat map, from yellow (a little) to red (where you paddled the most), with the minutes paddling. The **Paddling** button turns it off and on.
- **Replay the session:** plays the waves across the map in the order they came, over a timeline with one bar per wave. Below, one card per wave: tap one to open it.

- **Then,** the figures (the waves, the best, the longest, the top speed, the distance paddled, the caught ones), the time surfing, paddling and waiting, and what the sea was like when you went in.
- **Stars and tags** are changed here (the pencil): they stay on the phone and count toward your stars in the forecast.

A wave

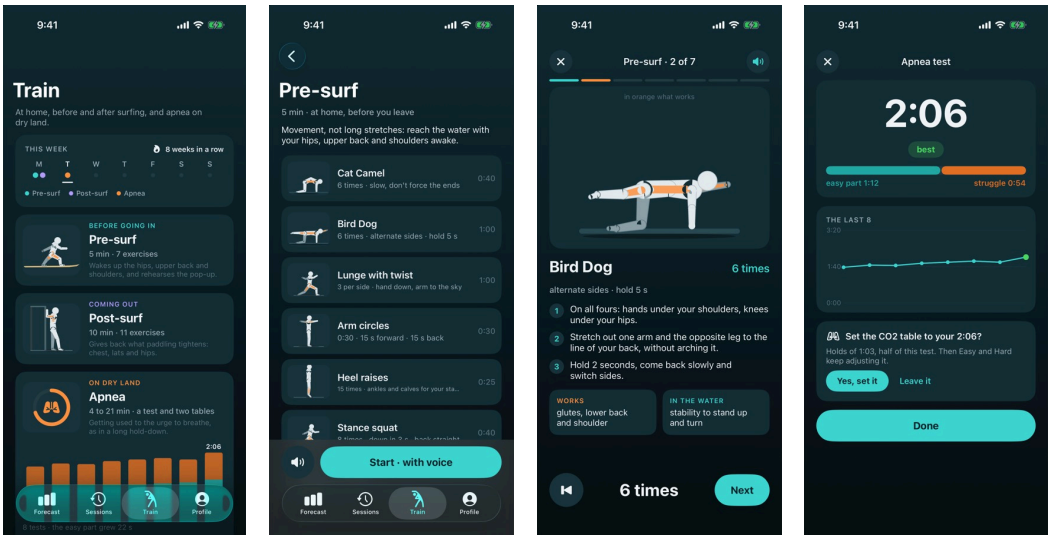
The map close to the wave, with the time you stood up and how long it lasted (the other waves, dimmed); the duration, the distance, the top and average speed, the strokes, the manoeuvres, the pop-up and whether you were facing the wave or had your back to it (with your stance); where it ranks among the session's waves; and the one before and the one after. Strokes, manoeuvres and the pop-up come from Session on Garmin: the Apple Watch doesn't measure them yet.

The photos of that day

- **Add photos from that day → Look in the camera roll:** Surf Dawn looks for the photos taken of you during the session (from a quarter of an hour before to a quarter of an hour after) within 3 km of the spot, or with no location (those from a camera copied to the phone). Add them all or choose which ones.
- The Photos permission is asked for only then.
- **The photos stay in your camera roll:** the session keeps which ones they are. Each photo goes with the wave its time falls in; opened, it says how long after you stood up it was taken and on which wave, and it can be shared. **Remove from the session** takes it out of the session, not out of the camera roll.

Train

At home: before and after surfing, and apnea on dry land. They're the same exercises, times and tables as Session on Garmin, with each exercise better explained and with a voice.



- **Tomorrow** (or **Today**): Pre-surf 20 minutes before the best window of the best spot ("Pre-surf at 05:40"). **Remind me** sends you a notification at that time.
- **This week:** what you did each day and how many weeks in a row you've kept it up.
- **Pre-surf** (7 exercises, 5 minutes, at home before you leave): movement, not long stretches; it wakes up the hips, the upper back and the shoulders, and rehearses the pop-up.
- **Post-surf** (11 exercises, 10 minutes, back from the water): gentle 30-second stretches, no bouncing; it gives back what paddling shortens: chest, lats and hips.
- **Each exercise, one screen:** the list shows each one's figure; **Start** goes to one exercise per screen, with its figure moving (in orange what works), how it's done, what it works and what it's for in the water. The timed ones count by themselves and tell you halfway when to switch sides. The voice says each step (**With voice** / **No voice**) and the screen stays on. With Reduce Motion, the figures stay still, in the starting pose with their arrows.

Apnea, always on dry land

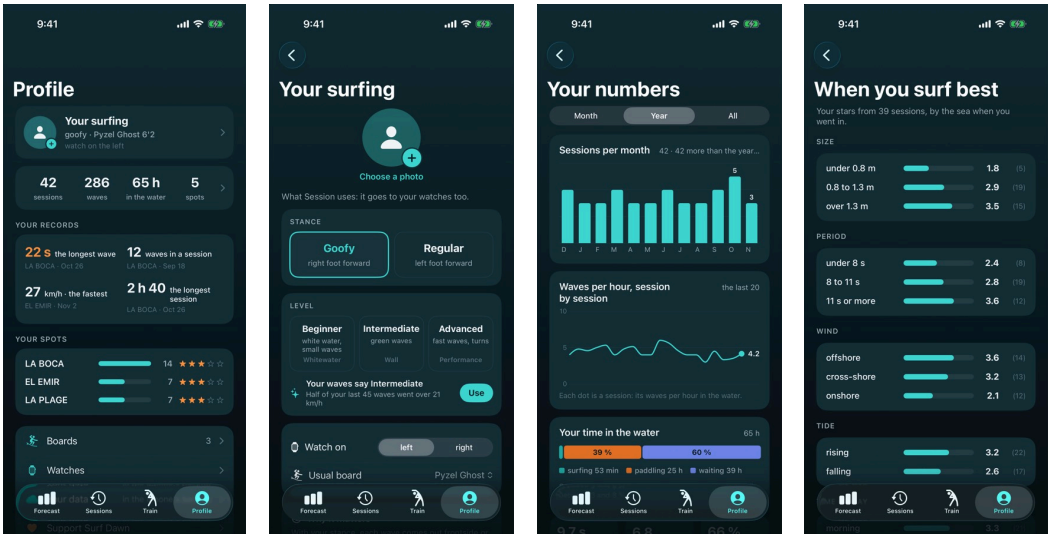
> **Never in the water or driving:** a long hold can end in a blackout with no warning. Before a hold, one calm breath in: hyperventilating gives you no more air and makes a blackout more likely.

The Apnea card shows your best and your **easy part** test by test.

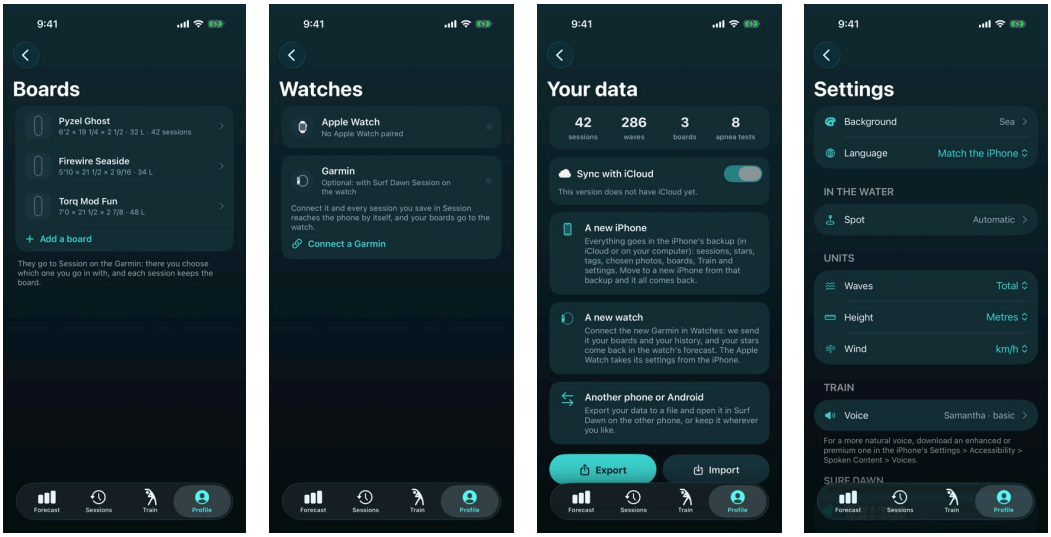
- **Apnea test:** 1:50 of calm breathing (in for 4 seconds, out for 6), 10 seconds for one deep breath in, and hold. When you feel the **first contraction** (the diaphragm pushing to breathe), mark it: what comes before is the easy part, what comes after the struggle. Over time the easy part grows. The result is compared with your best and your last 8 tests, and it offers to set the CO2 table to half the test. The iPhone doesn't measure heart rate or SpO2 (the Garmin does).
- **CO2 table:** short holds with rests that get shorter; it trains bearing the CO2, what you feel in a long hold-down.
- **O2 table:** holds that grow up to near your best, with 2 minutes of breathing between them; it trains bearing little oxygen. It needs a test first.
- **At the end of a table,** "How was it?": **Easy**, **Fine** or **Hard**. The next one adjusts to what you say.

The voice is the best one installed for the app's language. You choose it in Profile → Settings → **Voice**: **Automatic** or any of the installed ones (tap one to hear it). For a more natural voice, download an enhanced or premium one in the iPhone's Settings → Accessibility → Spoken Content → Voices; apps can't use Siri's voices.

Profile



- **Your surfing,** at the top (see below).
- **Your numbers in a row:** sessions, waves, hours in the water and spots. Tap it to open Your numbers.
- **Your records:** the longest wave, most waves in a session, the fastest and the longest session.
- **Your spots:** how many sessions you've done at each one and your stars there.
- **At the bottom:** Boards, Watches, Your data, Support Surf Dawn and Settings.



Your surfing

What Session uses: it goes to your watches too.

- **Stance:** goofy (right foot forward) or regular (left foot forward). With your stance, each wave comes out frontside or backside, and Pre-surf's pop-up faces your way.
- **Level:** beginner (white water, small waves), intermediate (green waves) or advanced (fast waves, turns). With your level, Session picks how it detects your waves on both watches: Whitewater, Wall or Performance. In the white water it takes slower, shorter rides; on fast waves it asks for more speed, so hard paddling isn't taken for a wave. With at least 10 waves, the app suggests a level (from the top speed of your last waves) and **Use** picks it. It changes the watch's detection only when you change the level: if you then pick another one on the watch, that one stays.
- **Watch on:** the left or the right wrist. With it, Session on Garmin adjusts how it measures the pop-up.
- **Usual board:** the one Session takes until you choose another.
- **Your photo:** tap the photo circle (here or in Profile) to choose it from the camera roll. The iPhone's photo picker doesn't ask for permission: only the photo you choose reaches the app. It stays on the iPhone.

Your stance, wrist and level go to Session on the Garmin, the same as if you changed them on the watch; your level also goes to Session on the Apple Watch.

Your numbers

For the **Month**, the **Year** (the last 12 months) or **All**: sessions per day or per month; waves per hour, session by session (each dot is a session); your time in the water surfing, paddling and waiting; the mean wave, waves per session and the waves caught out of those attempted.

When you surf best: your stars by size, period, wind, tide and time of day when you went in (morning, midday or afternoon), and your best combination. The bar goes up to 5 stars; in brackets, how many sessions. Rate your sessions with stars to see it.

Boards

Each board with its photo, its model, the length, the width, the thickness and the litres (**Add a board**). They go to Session on the Garmin, all but the photo, and replace the ones in the Connect IQ app: on the watch you choose which one you go in with, and each session keeps the board. The photo stays on the iPhone.

Watches

- **Apple Watch:** it says whether one is paired and whether it has Surf Dawn. There's nothing to connect: the watch sends its sessions by itself.
- **Garmin** (optional, with Surf Dawn Session on the watch): **Connect a Garmin** opens Garmin Connect, which the watch is already paired with, to choose it; if you don't have Garmin Connect, the app tells you. Then it shows whether Forecast and Session are installed on the watch.

    - **Every session you save** on the Garmin arrives by itself, with its waves, its map, where you paddled and your stars. If the phone isn't nearby, it waits on the watch (up to 60) and goes the next time you open Session.
    - **Ask for the history:** brings up to 60 sessions from the watch's history, with the waves of the last 10.
    - **Send yours:** sends the watch your history (with your stars, which come back in the watch's forecast), your boards and Your surfing. When you connect a new watch it does this by itself. What the watch already had stays as it was.

Without the iPhone app, Session on Garmin works the same as always.

Your data

- **A new iPhone:** everything goes in the iPhone's backup (in iCloud or on your computer): sessions, stars, tags, chosen photos, boards, Train and settings. Move to a new iPhone from that backup and it all comes back.
- **Sync with iCloud** (on by default): your sessions, with their waves and where you paddled, your boards and Train go to your iCloud and show up on your other iPhones with the same Apple Account, on a new one, or on this one if you delete the app and install it again. If you change something on two phones, the last change wins; a session deleted on one is deleted on the others too. The board photos and the Profile photo don't travel (they stay on each phone); the session photos are in your camera roll. If you have no iCloud account, sign in to iCloud in the iPhone's Settings.
- **A new watch:** connect the new Garmin in Watches: we send it your boards and your history, and your stars come back in the watch's forecast.
- **Another phone or Android: Export** saves your data to a file (sessions, boards, Train and settings) to open in Surf Dawn on the other phone or keep wherever you like; **Import** adds what's missing.

Support Surf Dawn

Surf Dawn is free, with no ads and no accounts. If it helps you catch better waves, you can buy something for the one who makes it: a coffee, a beer or a pizza, at the App Store price in your currency. It's a one-time payment with your Apple Account and it doesn't unlock anything: everything stays just as free.

Settings

Setting	Values (factory default in bold)
Background	**Sea**, Night, Graphite, Forest or Light (phone only). Below, two switches: Match the iPhone (off by default) uses Light with the iPhone's light mode and your dark background with dark mode; The same on the watches (on by default) sends the background to the Apple Watch too. Light stays on the phone only, because on the watches a light background uses more battery
Language	**Match the iPhone**, Español, English or Português. The whole app changes at once; the Apple Watch's is chosen on the watch
Spot	the one the ranking centres on: **Automatic** (the nearest to where you are), a spot from your Saved zones or from The whole world
Waves	**Total** (the whole sea) or Swell (only the groundswell)
Height	**Metres** or Feet
Wind	**km/h** or Knots
Voice	**Automatic** or one of the installed voices for the language (see Train)
Write a review	opens Surf Dawn in the App Store to write one
Privacy, Support	Surf Dawn's pages
Version	the installed version

What the system draws (the photo picker, the permission prompts, the share sheet) follows the iPhone's language, or the one you choose for Surf Dawn in the iPhone's Settings.

Frequently asked questions

Do I need a watch? No. Forecast, Train and Profile work on their own; sessions come from Session on a Garmin or on the Apple Watch.

Why does the iPhone's ranking have more spots than Today on the watch? The iPhone compares all the spots of your zone within 25 km; the watches, the 12 nearest, because on Garmin the morning alert doesn't have the memory for more.

Do my Garmin sessions show up in Health? No: they stay in Garmin Connect and in the app. The Apple Watch ones do, as a Surfing workout with its map.

A session doesn't show the waves on the satellite. The Garmin keeps where each wave was for its last 10 sessions, and Session started saving it on 27 October 2026. For the others, the app draws the waves from the take-off zone of another session at that spot, and says so.

Do the stars I change on the iPhone go back to the watch? Yes, when you send it your history (Watches → Send yours, or when you connect a new watch), and your stars come back in its forecast.

Appendix: data and models

Where each number on the watch face, in Forecast and in Session comes from, why those models, and what their limitations are.

Where each number comes from

Element	What it shows	Where it comes from
Sunrise / sunset	Next sunrise and sunset	Open-Meteo, for today and tomorrow
Battery	The watch's battery %	Green above 50 %, yellow from 20 to 50 %, red below 20 %
Stale data / no phone	Below the date (in Digital, below the battery), only when something fails	With data older than 3 h the values show **in grey** and "4 H AGO" appears in red; with no connection to the phone a **crossed-out phone** appears (in that state no updates arrive)
Water	Sea temperature	Open-Meteo's marine model (Météo-France), at the spot in use; neighbouring spots use the same
Outside	Air temperature + weather icon; the **number's colour is the UV risk** (white with no sun, green low, yellow moderate, orange high, red very high, violet extreme)	The Garmin's own weather (from the phone, the same as its weather app) when it's from the last 3 hours and less than 25 km from the spot; otherwise the Open-Meteo forecast with the zone's wind model. The model can get the sky wrong: on 26/10 GFS gave sun, 15° and UV 8 at La Plage under an overcast sky
Waves	Height (m), period (s) and direction of origin. **Swell traffic light:** the arrow and the period are green if it comes in head-on to the beach (up to 35° off), yellow if diagonal (up to 75°) and red if from the side or from behind (blocked beach)	Open-Meteo, with the wave model of the spot's zone (Models by zone): in Uruguay and Santa Catarina **NOAA GFS Wave**, the same one Windguru shows. When the model point nearest the spot falls on land (as on Florianópolis' east coast, for example), the waves are requested at a point offshore. By default it is the **total** sea (Windguru's "Wave" row); in Customize you can pick the ground **swell** only (off Uruguay the model splits the swell poorly, and in zones with ECMWF WAM there is no separate swell: the total is shown)
Wind	km/h and the compass point it comes from	Open-Meteo, with the zone's wind model; **GFS** by default (Windguru's "GFS 13 km"). The colour depends on where the beach faces: **green offshore** (up to 45° from the land wind), **yellow cross-shore** (up to 110°) and **red onshore**

Element	What it shows	Where it comes from
Tide	24 h curve with high and low tides, time and current height	The table of the **nearest port** of the zone that covers the spot. In Uruguay, the **official SOHMA table**: Montevideo (up to 89 km: Playa Honda, La Pantalla and the Costa de Oro to Costa Azul), Punta del Este (up to 60 km: from Biarritz to Jaureguiberry and from La Virgen to José Ignacio) and La Paloma (up to 135 km: all of Rocha to Chuy, at most 10 to 20 min off), in metres above each port's datum. In Santa Catarina, the **official DHN (Brazilian Navy) table for Imbituba** (up to 100 km: from Praia da Vila to Praia Brava), published by Epagri/CIRAM. Elsewhere, the official predictions that can be republished (**NOAA** in the US, Hawaii, Puerto Rico and the Pacific; **JMA** in Japan; **Marine Institute** in Ireland; **LINZ** in New Zealand) and, where there are none, the nearest tide gauge on the same coast (**TICON-3**) or, with no gauge nearby (Argentina, Central America, much of Indonesia, the Maldives, Africa…), NASA's global **GOT5.6** model. If the month can't be downloaded, the watch computes it from the port's constants (±4 cm in Uruguay). Far from any port, Open-Meteo's hourly sea level. It is the astronomical tide: it doesn't include the wind

The watch face requests data in the background every **30 minutes**, and every **15 minutes between 5 and 10**, the first hours of surfing. The hourly forecast for the spot in use comes every three hours or when the spot changes. If part of a request fails, the last values of that part are kept. Values turn grey after 3 h without new data ("N H AGO", and "N D AGO" from 48 h).

Which spot the watch face uses

- **Spot:** the one you pinned on the watch or in Forecast; if there is none, the nearest one within **25 km** among the zones saved on the watch; if there is none, the backup spot in the phone settings (La Plage by default). The face doesn't turn on GPS: it uses the watch's last position, from its last GPS or, without a GPS activity, the one the phone passes on, which can be several kilometres off (in Punta del Este it was 19 km away). Opening Session until the GPS turns green fixes it. If you travelled more than 50 km, the phone's weather position counts too. The spot is checked every 10 minutes.
- **Zones:** spots come in zones of up to 60, from the public data repo. Uruguay's come with the apps; the others (Santa Catarina included) download on their own when you get there, 2 or 3 KB each. Each app keeps up to 10 zones besides the built-in ones; when there is no room, it removes the auto-downloaded one you used least (never one you downloaded by hand). What is saved on the watch never gets it stuck: when space runs out, old zones, saved tides and old forecasts go first. Session's history is never deleted to make room for something else. A zone that changed in the repo is downloaded again at most once a week.
- **Preloaded spots:** every update also brings the spots of the same zone within 25 km (up to 8), so switching to one next door is instant. A faraway spot picked by hand waits for the next background update: Garmin allows one every 5 minutes, and meanwhile the face says LOADING.
- **Orientation:** each spot knows where its beach faces, computed from the OpenStreetMap coastline. It decides the swell and wind colours.

Forecast and Session data

Both apps request the data themselves when they open (Forecast also with START or when you pick a spot), without waiting for the background: the waves and wind of the zone's models hour by hour, air and sun from the wind model, water from the marine model and the same tide as the face. The last forecast is kept for three hours: opening again in that time asks for nothing. Periods and temperatures are rounded like Windguru (9.55 s → 10 s). After 19:00 the forecast starts tomorrow.

Models by zone

Each zone brings its wave and wind models, chosen in the data repo:

- **Uruguay, Santa Catarina and Argentina: GFS Wave + GFS**, like Windguru, the reference for people who surf there (see below).
- **Everywhere else:** GFS Wave and GFS by default. Where there are buoys, the data repo compares Open-Meteo's models against them every month (NDBC and CDIP in the US, IMOS/AODN in Australia and the Marine Institute in Ireland) and the zone switches models when another one is clearly less wrong. Only models that give the **peak period**, the one the watch shows, are chosen: GFS Wave or **ECMWF WAM** (which gives the total sea, with no separate swell). In the October 2026 validation ECMWF WAM won on the US west coast, Hawaii, Baja California, the Gulf of Mexico, the US northeast, British Columbia, South Australia, Northern Ireland and Clare/Kerry, with 5 to 60 % less height error than GFS Wave (20 to 45 % in most; half in Hawaii and Los Angeles). For wind, ECMWF IFS won in the US southeast and GEM (Canada) in Puerto Rico; elsewhere GFS stays.

Uruguay: why GFS Wave + GFS

On 2026-10-07 Open-Meteo's models were compared with what Windguru shows for Punta del Este (Parada 31). Windguru's waves are **GFS-Wave 25 km** (NOAA) and its wind is **GFS 13 km**. In Open-Meteo, GFS Wave gave practically the same (for example 2.06 m / 9.6 s against 2.1 m / 10 s), while the default model (Météo-France) gave 0.3 to 0.4 m less and 2 to 3 s less period, and its wind was off by up to 5 knots; GFS matched. That is why the apps ask for those two models. Tide and water temperature don't exist in GFS Wave and come from the default model.

Spot positions and orientation: derived from the © OpenStreetMap contributors coastline (ODbL). Tides outside Uruguay and Brazil: NOAA/NOS/CO-OPS (public domain), JMA (Public Data License 1.0), Marine Institute (CC BY 4.0), LINZ (CC BY 4.0, Crown copyright), TICON-3 (Hart-Davis et al. 2022, CC BY 4.0, GESLA-3 data) and GOT5.6 (R. Ray, NASA GSFC, public domain). Forecast: Open-Meteo (CC BY 4.0).

The best hours (Forecast)

Each daylight hour gets a score from 0 to 1:

- **Waves:** 65 % for height (0 at 0.3 m, full at 1.8 m) plus 35 % for period (0 at 5 s, full at 13 s).
- **Wind:** it doesn't subtract up to a speed that depends on the direction: 35 km/h up to 20° off offshore, 12 at 80° (cross-shore) and 8 from 140° (onshore), in a straight line between those angles. Above it, the score drops until it is 15 % at three times that limit.
- **Swell exposure:** full head-on (up to 15° off), three quarters at 55° (diagonal), a third from 100° (blocked), in a straight line in between.
- **Spot shelter:** for each spot, in 18 directions, whether there is land within 2 km, within 25 km or open sea (from the OpenStreetMap coastline). Wind that crosses land close by counts no worse than halfway between offshore and cross-shore (within 25 km, than cross-shore): over so little water it raises almost no chop. Swell with land in the way is worth at most a third (within 25 km, three quarters). A spot with no known orientation counts as blocked and onshore.
- **The other swell:** of the two biggest swells GFS Wave splits out, the bigger one that comes from 30° or more away from the page's waves and is at least 0.3 m (below that only its period added up, with 10 or 20 cm). Each hour is worth what the one that comes in better at the beach is worth, the page's waves or the other swell, and the traffic light goes by that one. It is drawn only where it matters: where it is the one that counts or brings at least half the energy of the page's waves (height^2 × period^2): in 4 % of the hours of a month in 29 zones, against 30 % if it were always drawn. Over a month (28/09 to 30/10/2026), in the Uruguay zones it improved the traffic light in 2.8 % of the daylight hours and changed the alert's best spot on 2 of 102 days; in 26 GFS Wave zones in the rest of the world, on 12 of 884 days (9 at Jeffreys Bay). Adding the third swell changed the best spot on a single day of those 884. ECMWF WAM doesn't split the swell out: its zones have no other swell.

The band marks the 3 consecutive hours with the best average, all in daylight (from the sunrise hour, or the next one if the sun rises at half past or later, to the sunset hour), and only if that average is above 0.1. Today it can fall on hours that have already passed.

The stars (Session)

For each forecast hour, Session looks for your rated sessions (1 to 5) **at the same spot** with similar conditions: height, period, how far the swell is off the beach, wind and its direction, tide (and whether it is rising or falling) and time of day. The more a session resembles it, the more it weighs; with the tide in the other phase it weighs half. The stars are the average of your ratings with those weights, and "N sessions" counts the ones that really resemble it.

- **History + estimate:** with fewer than 3 similar sessions, it adds the forecast's estimate (the best-hours score, in stars) as if it were one and a half sessions.
- **History only:** with no similar sessions, it shows no stars.
- **Best window:** the two consecutive hours between 6:00 and 20:00 with the most stars; worked out when each session is saved.

Recommended wetsuit (Session)

The forecast water temperature for the hour, one degree less with wind from 20 to 29 km/h, two with 30 km/h or more, and one less if the air is more than 4 °C below the water. The cut-offs (table in The recommended wetsuit) come from the guides by Rip Curl, Vissla, evo and Sendy, which agree on the order (4/3, then booties, then gloves and hood) and differ by one or two degrees between brands.

Wave detection (Session)

How it counts waves, attempts and strokes is in How waves are counted.

Pop-up (Session)

It's a provisional rule, written before having real take-offs to tune it with. When Session confirms a wave, it looks at how the wrist moved from 6 s before to 6 s after the moment it started, with the accelerometer and the gyroscope, 25 times a second:

1. **The push:** a stretch with the wrist rotating faster than 152 °/s, with the accelerometer deviating at least 0.5 g, up or down, around it (the arms leave the board). It can be from 4 s before to 3 s after the start of the wave.
2. **Still hands before:** right before the push (at most 0.2 s of rise), the wrist below 60 °/s (for about 0.28 s or more). The pop-up starts where that stillness starts, that is, where the last stroke ended.
3. **A stroke in the preceding second** (over 120 °/s): if you weren't paddling it isn't a take-off.
4. **Standing:** after the push peak, the first moment the wrist stays under 100 °/s for 0.32 s. That is where the pop-up ends.
5. Between 0.32 s and 3 s; if more than one push qualifies, the strongest.

Without a gyroscope, or if the pause of the hands doesn't show up, there is no pop-up ("—" on the watch, 0 in Garmin Connect). The thresholds come from the expected movement, not from wrist measurements: they will be tuned with real sessions recorded in Calibrate.

What the studies say (all on land, with a force platform; there are no confirmed published numbers for in the water, nor for beginners):

Who	From → to	Time	Source
Competitive surfers, men (9)	chest lifts off → front foot lands	0.56 ± 0.06 s	Parsonage et al. 2018
Competitive surfers, women (8)	Same	0.68 ± 0.07 s	Same
Experienced recreational surfers (23 men)	hands touch the board → weight stable	1.20 ± 0.19 s	Borgonovo-Santos et al. 2021
Intermediates, ~25 years old	Same	1.12 ± 0.16 s	Enticott 2024 (thesis)
Intermediates, ~52 years old	Same	2.03 ± 0.52 s	Same

The watch measures the second kind (from hands on the board to being stable), which includes the landing. Borgonovo-Santos splits it into pushing with the hands on the board 0.71 ± 0.08 s, transition ~0 s and from landing to being stable 0.48 ± 0.22 s. No study publishes what the pop-up looks like at the wrist (g or °/s): those that use body-worn sensors put them on the back, the

sacrum or the legs.